

**Work-life Balance of Students
in South Korea and in the Czech Republic**

Diploma Thesis

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Guides to writing a thesis:

1. The objective of this thesis is to explore how students perceive the balance between their academic, work, and personal lives (work-study-life balance) in South Korea and the Czech Republic. The research will focus on students from PKNU (Pukyong National University) in South Korea and Mendel University in the Czech Republic. The thesis will examine how students manage the combination of academic obligations, work commitments, and personal life, and how this balance affects their mental wellbeing, performance, and life satisfaction.
2. Methodological framework:
A questionnaire survey will be conducted among students from PKNU and Mendel University, focusing on their experiences with combining study, work, and personal life. The questionnaires will gather information on:
 - a) The number of hours dedicated to study, work, and leisure activities.
 - b) The level of stress associated with the combination of academic and work commitments.
 - c) Satisfaction with personal life and perception of balance.
 - d) The impact of work commitments on academic performance and personal well-being
3. Suitable methods of quantitative (descriptive and inferential statistics) data analysis will be used. On the basis of the results conclusions will be made and discussed with respect to the state-of-art in the field.
4. The structure of the thesis will be in accordance with valid dean's norm of FRRMS Mendelu. The citations will be done according to the ISO690 or APA reference norm.

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Declaration

I, Natálie Svobodová, confirm by submitting that this thesis entitled *Work-life Balance of Students in South Korea and in the Czech Republic* was written and completed by me. I also declare that all the sources and information used to complete the thesis are included in the list of references.

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Abstract

This thesis investigates work–study–life balance among university students in South Korea and in the Czech Republic. The primary objective is to determine how the demands of academic responsibilities, employment, and personal life shape students’ overall wellbeing and overall satisfaction. The study evaluates cross-group differences between the two populations. The theoretical part outlines the development of work–life balance and its relevance for students combining academic, work, and personal roles. It summarizes the main determinants influencing work–study–life balance and conceptualizes well-being through hedonic and eudaimonic perspectives. Furthermore, the methodology and collected data are presented in detail. The empirical part is mainly based on data analysis, using quantitative methods. Finally, the key results of the study are presented and interpreted. According to the findings, Czech and Korean university students differ in some areas how they experience and manage study, work, and personal life demands. Korean students reported higher study time, academic stress, and stress related to social expectations and future uncertainty, while Czech students reported higher engagement in paid work and work-related stress. Czech students also showed higher emotional exhaustion and stronger strain in health and relationships, whereas Korean students reported higher anxiety and overload. Czech students expressed higher satisfaction with work–study–life balance.

Keywords

work-life balance, work-study-life balance, well-being, stress, university students, cross-cultural comparison, South Korea and Czech Republic

Abstrakt

Tato diplomová práce zkoumá rovnováhu mezi studiem, prací a osobním životem u vysokoškolských studentů v Jižní Koreji a v České republice a analyzuje její dopad na jejich psychickou, fyziologickou a sociální pohodu. Hlavním cílem je zjistit, jak současné požadavky akademických povinností, zaměstnání a osobního života formují celkové fungování studentů. Studie porovnává rozdíly mezi oběma skupinami studentů. Teoretická část se zabývá vývojem konceptu rovnováhy mezi pracovním a osobním životem a jeho významem pro studenty, kteří kombinují studijní, pracovní a osobní role. Shrnuje hlavní faktory ovlivňující rovnováhu mezi studiem, prací a osobním životem a konceptualizuje well-being z hlediska hedonického a eudaimonického přístupu. Dále je podrobně představena metodologie a sběr empirických dat. Empirická část je založena především na analýze dat pomocí kvantitativních metod. Podle zjištění se čeští a korejští univerzitní studenti lišili v tom, jak vnímali a zvládali určité požadavky studia, práce a osobního života. Korejští studenti vykazovali vyšší studijní zátěž, akademický stres a stres spojený se sociálními očekáváními a nejistotou budoucnosti, zatímco čeští studenti vykazovali vyšší zapojení do placené práce a vyšší pracovní stres. Čeští studenti také vykazovali vyšší emoční vyčerpání a silnější zátěž v oblasti zdraví a mezilidských vztahů, zatímco korejští studenti uváděli vyšší úzkost a přetížení. Čeští studenti zároveň vyjádřili vyšší spokojenost s rovnováhou mezi studiem, prací a osobním životem.

Klíčová slova

Rovnováha mezi prací, studiem a osobním životem, well-being, stres, vysokoškolští studenti, mezinárodní srovnání, Jižní Korea a Česká republika

Table of Contents

1	Introduction	10
2	THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK	12
2.1	Work-Life Balance	12
2.1.1	Evolution of the Concept.....	12
2.1.2	Definition of WLB	13
2.1.3	WSLB Among University Students	14
2.1.4	Theoretical Approaches to WSLB.....	15
2.1.5	Determinants of WSLB	17
2.1.5.1	Individual Factors	17
2.1.5.2	Academic Factors	17
2.1.5.3	Work-related Factors	17
2.1.5.4	Environmental and Social Factors.....	18
2.1.5.5	Technological Factors.....	18
2.2	Well-being in the Context of Work–Study–Life Balance	19
2.2.1	Conceptualizing Well-being.....	19
2.2.2	WSLB and Student Well-being	20
2.2.3	Lifestyle Patterns	21
2.2.3.1	Time Allocation and Management	21
2.2.3.2	Sleep Hygiene.....	21
2.2.3.3	Leisure Time.....	22
2.2.4	Consequences of WSLB Imbalance	23
2.2.4.1	Psychological Consequences.....	23
2.2.4.2	Physiological Consequences	23
2.2.5	Mental Health Service Use Among Students	24
2.3	Cultural Contexts of Work–Study–Life Balance.....	26
2.3.1	Cultural Frameworks Relevant to WSLB.....	26
2.3.1.1	Hofstede’s Cultural Dimensions.....	26
2.3.1.2	Cultural Tightness–Looseness.....	28
2.3.2	Work–Study–Life Balance in South Korea	29
2.3.2.1	Confucian Heritage.....	29
2.3.2.2	Academic and Work Culture in South Korea.....	30
2.3.3	Work–Study–Life Balance in the Czech Republic.....	31
2.3.3.1	European Humanist Values	31

2.3.3.2	Academic and Work Culture in the Czech Republic.....	31
3	METHODOLOGY.....	33
3.1	Research Design	33
3.1.1	Questionnaire Structure	34
3.1.2	Language and Translation	35
3.1.3	Research Ethics.....	35
3.1.4	Use of AI Tools	35
3.2	Data Collection	36
3.2.1	Pukyong National University	36
3.2.2	Mendel University in Brno	36
3.3	Data Analysis.....	36
3.4	Aim of Research	37
3.4.1	Research Questions and Hypotheses	37
4	RESULTS.....	42
4.1	Research Sample.....	42
4.1.1	Korean Participants.....	42
4.1.2	Czech Participants	43
4.1.3	Employment Status.....	44
4.2	Time Allocation.....	45
4.3	Work-Study-Life Balance.....	49
4.4	Well-being and Stress	51
4.5	Cultural and Social Perceptions.....	60
4.6	Life Satisfaction.....	62
5	Discussion	65
5.1	Limitations of the Study	67
6	Conclusion.....	69
	References.....	71
	List of Figures	88
	List of Tables.....	88
	List of Abbreviations.....	90
	Attachments	91

1 Introduction

In recent years, everyday life has been shaped by rapid social and technological changes that place increasing demands on individuals. The fast pace of modern society, combined with rising expectations and constant digital connectivity, influences how people organize their responsibilities and balance different areas of their lives. The pressure to perform efficiently in such conditions may lead to a sense of overload, making the search for stability and well-being more important than ever.

For university students, these pressures are even more pronounced. The demands of study, employment, and personal life often overlap, creating multiple responsibilities that must be managed simultaneously. Many students work part-time or participate in internships while managing coursework, deadlines, and preparation for future careers. At the same time, they must maintain relationships, take care of their health, and find time to rest. This combination of roles creates a demanding environment in which students frequently face time conflicts, psychological strain, and the need to constantly redistribute their limited energy and attention. Therefore, the concept of work–study–life balance has become increasingly relevant for understanding the realities of student life.

Closely connected to this matter is the broader question of student well-being, which encompasses not only mental and physical health but also motivation, emotional stability, and the ability to cope with everyday challenges. Well-being plays a central role in how students experience their studies and personal development, influencing their capacity to stay engaged, make decisions, and maintain a sense of personal fulfillment.

Several studies have explored how students navigate the overall demands of university life and how these experiences relate to their well-being, with most findings showing that maintaining a sense of balance is often difficult to achieve. Vokić et al. (2021) argue that students simultaneously juggle three core roles as learners, workers, and individuals with personal and social responsibilities and that the constant shifting between academic tasks, job duties, and personal life creates significant pressure, making them particularly vulnerable to overload and role conflict. Another research carried out by Amez et al. (2021) shows that rising academic pressure and irregular study routines significantly increase stress levels, frequently resulting in reduced concentration and lower academic performance. Furthermore, according to research conducted in the Philippines (Tecson

et al., 2025) student employment can have both beneficial and detrimental effects. The authors suggest that while work may provide financial stability and valuable experience, long or inflexible working hours tend to undermine well-being and limit students' ability to meet academic expectations. Lastly, Siem et al. (2025) investigate the role of cultural context and report that cultural norms and institutional structures strongly shape how students negotiate their responsibilities, which suggests that the experience of balance varies across national contexts.

As student well-being is a key component of healthy development and sustained functioning, maintaining it has become an increasingly important societal concern. Given the pressures faced by the student population and their vulnerability to stress, it is essential to examine the conditions that influence their ability to maintain stability and overall life satisfaction. Addressing work–study–life balance therefore plays a crucial role in understanding and supporting student well-being.

2 THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

2.1 Work-Life Balance

Work–life balance (WLB) has become a key analytical concept across several disciplines, reflecting the increasing complexity of balancing multiple social roles (Björk Fant et al., 2023). As work intensifies and digital connectivity expands, WLB is increasingly understood as a multidimensional concept that mirrors how individuals manage competing demands and maintain overall well-being (Sharma et al., 2025). Its relevance extends to employees, caregivers, and students, highlighting its role in understanding responses to modern social and institutional pressures (Rašticová & Konečný, 2016).

2.1.1 Evolution of the Concept

The evolution of the WLB concept mirrors broader societal changes in work organization, family structures, and cultural expectations. Early research in the 1970s and 1980s conceptualized balance primarily as work–family balance, framing the “life” domain in terms of caregiving and domestic responsibilities, particularly for women entering the workforce (O’Brien & Wall, 2017). As demographic patterns shifted, characterized by more single workers, dual-earner couples, and individuals without children, the narrow family -centered perspective became insufficient (Gagnano et al., 2020).

Technological change further accelerated this conceptual expansion. The rise of digital communication and mobile technologies blurred temporal and spatial boundaries between work and personal life, creating more fluid role transitions and increasing the need for theoretical approaches that address boundary regulation, psychological detachment, and effective recovery processes (Vyas, 2022).

In addition to demographic and technological shifts, economic transformations have significantly shaped the evolution of WLB. The transition toward knowledge-based economies, the rise of flexible employment, and performance-driven work cultures have increased pressure on individuals to remain constantly available and productive (ILO, 2022).

As the concept expanded beyond its original work–family focus, researchers increasingly recognized that non-work life encompasses not only family but also leisure, health, social

relationships or personal development (Daly, 2019). At the same time, growing demands for flexibility and autonomy reshaped how individuals manage their roles, emphasizing that balance involves both separating and integrating work and life domains in meaningful ways (Gragnano et al., 2020).

2.1.2 Definition of WLB

Although definitions of work–life balance (WLB) vary across academic disciplines, most approaches share the view that balance represents a subjective evaluation of how effectively individuals integrate their work and non-work roles.

From a psychological perspective, WLB is primarily understood as a subjective state of equilibrium that enables individuals to meet work and non-work demands without experiencing excessive strain (Brough et al., 2020). One of the most influential definitions in this field is offered by Kalliath and Brough (2008), who describe WLB as “*the individual perception that work and non-work activities are compatible and promote growth in accordance with an individual’s current life priorities*” (p. 326). Psychological approaches therefore emphasize the evaluative nature of balance, highlighting the role of personal expectations, role salience, and perceived psychological resources in managing competing demands (Gragnano et al., 2020).

Sociological perspectives expand the concept of WLB, situating it within broader structural and cultural contexts. At the macro level, balance is shaped by institutional arrangements such as welfare regimes, gender norms, and labor market conditions (Zaitouni et al., 2024). This perspective is reflected in Clark’s (2000) definition, which views WLB as the extent to which individuals negotiate the boundaries between work and family “*in accordance with the norms and expectations of their larger social and organizational context*” (p. 751). To bridge macro-level structures and individual experience, Voydanoff (2005) conceptualizes WLB as a “*global assessment that work and family resources are sufficient to meet work and family demands such that participation is effective in both domains*” (p. 825). Together, this illustrates that WLB emerges from the interaction between structural conditions and micro-level role experiences, making it a socially embedded outcome rather than a purely individual responsibility (Thilagavathy & Geetha, 2023).

In public health research, WLB is viewed as a determinant of physical and mental well-being, particularly in relation to stress, burnout, and long-term health outcomes. ILO (2022) defines WLB as a state in which work demands do not undermine essential health-promoting behaviors such as adequate sleep, recovery, and psychological functioning. Sharma et al. (2025) take a similar view and describe it as “*a central pillar of faculty well-being and productivity*” (p. 2) and highlight that insufficient balance contributes to “*emotional fatigue, chronic stress, anxiety, burnout, and emotional exhaustion*” (p. 2).

Recent research shows that these views alone cannot fully capture the complexity of how people combine their work and non-work roles. To address this division, modern interdisciplinary research seeks to clarify and further standardize the concept (Thilagavathy & Geetha, 2023). A major contribution in this direction comes from Casper et al. (2018), who argue that WLB is best understood as an overarching evaluative judgment in which individuals assess how well their work and non-work roles fit together considering their personal values, expectations, and priorities.

While WLB primarily refers to the interaction between work and non-work domains, this thesis extends the concept to work–study–life balance (WSLB), which incorporates the additional academic responsibilities of students. Vokić et al. (2021) define WSLB as the balance among “*three categories of student commitment – work obligations, demands of their studies, and their private life*” (p. 78).

2.1.3 WSLB Among University Students

According to Vokić et al. (2021) students compose a distinct social group whose everyday functioning is shaped by the simultaneous performance of three core roles:

- the role of a student
- the role of a worker
- the role of an individual

Students’ experience differs fundamentally from that of traditional employees, who typically balance only two domains, work and personal life, whereas students navigate a triadic system in which academic responsibilities intersect with employment and personal obligations (Siem et al., 2025). Academic study requires sustained cognitive

effort, continuous preparation, and the ability to manage fluctuating workloads across the semester, often marked by periods of intense pressure (Amez et al., 2021). In contrast, the work role is characterized by performance expectations and accountability to an employer, often driven by financial necessity rather than personal choice (Tecson et al., 2025). The third domain, personal life, covers health maintenance, social relationships, domestic responsibilities, and the need for rest and recovery (Ashour et al., 2026). The combination of these three domains creates a demanding environment for students regularly face time conflicts, psychological overload, and the need to constantly reallocate limited energy and attention (Amez et al., 2021).

2.1.4 Theoretical Approaches to WSLB

The complexity of student role systems is best understood through established sociological and psychological role theories, which provide the conceptual foundation for understanding WSLB in student populations.

Role Conflict Theory

RCT, as proposed by Kahn et al. (1964), conceptualizes role conflict as tension that emerges when individuals are confronted with expectations from different roles that cannot be met at the same time. The theory suggests that each role carries its own set of demands, and conflict occurs when fulfilling one role inevitably undermines the ability to meet the requirements of another.

Among students, such conflict commonly arises when work shifts interfere with study preparation, when academic deadlines overlap with personal responsibilities, or when emotional strain from one domain diminishes functioning in another (Soria et al., 2020). These conflicts may take the form of *time-based conflict*, where limited hours must be divided between competing roles, or *strain-based conflict*, where stress and fatigue spill over across domains, a phenomenon that is especially frequent given the variability of academic demands (Ayadurai, 2018).

Role Strain Theory

Goode (1960) introduces RST by arguing that individuals experience strain when the cumulative demands of their social roles exceed the resources, they have available to meet them. He emphasizes that individuals typically occupy multiple roles simultaneously, each carrying their own expectations, and that strain emerges when these expectations

compete for limited time, energy, or emotional capacity. According to Goode (1960), such strain is not an exception but a common feature of modern life, as individuals continually negotiate how to allocate their constrained resources across overlapping role obligations.

Students often operate with limited time, financial resources, and psychological capacity, increasing the likelihood that they will be unable to fulfil all role expectations adequately (Ayadurai, 2018; Tecson et al., 2025). Strain intensifies during examination periods, when academic requirements escalate sharply while work obligations remain constant, which may lead to the feelings of overload or reduced efficiency (Ashour et al., 2026).

Role Overload

Coverman (1989) conceptualizes RO as a situation in which the combined demands of multiple roles exceed the individual's available time, energy, or cognitive capacity. He argues that overload arises not only from the sheer number of roles a person occupies, but also from the intensity and simultaneity attached to them. In this view, overload reflects a structural imbalance between what roles require and what individuals are realistically able to provide.

Within the student population, this condition is particularly noticeable among those who engage in paid or non-paid work out of financial necessity, often taking on long or irregular shifts that substantially limit opportunities for study, adequate sleep, and recovery (Antipolo, 2021).

Boundary Theory

Clark's (2000) BT explains how individuals manage boundaries between different life domains, ranging from strict separation to integration. The theory emphasizes that individuals actively construct and negotiate these boundaries to maintain a sense of balance, yet the permeability and flexibility vary widely across different life domains.

Students often have very limited control over boundaries, as academic and employment schedules tend to be inflexible, and digital technologies make them constantly reachable for both study and work tasks (Tecson et al., 2025). Consequently, students commonly experience an unintentional blending of roles, where blurred boundaries make it difficult to mentally disconnect and recover, which in turn increases the likelihood of conflict and overload (Callender, 2008).

2.1.5 Determinants of WSLB

WSLB is shaped by a complex interplay of individual, academic, work, environmental, and technological factors. These determinants operate at multiple levels and interact dynamically, either supporting balance or contributing to conflict (Ayadurai, 2018).

2.1.5.1 *Individual Factors*

Individual factors refer to personal characteristics that influence how students handle the combined demands of work, study, and personal life. Psychological resources such as resilience, optimism, and self-efficacy help individuals cope with competing demands more effectively (Brough et al., 2020). Students with strong emotional regulation tend to navigate academic deadlines, work shifts, and personal responsibilities with greater ease (Callender, 2008). Time management is particularly important, as students who are able to prioritize tasks, plan ahead, and set realistic boundaries generally report higher levels of balance (Antipolo, 2021).

2.1.5.2 *Academic Factors*

Academic demands are a key determinant of WSLB, as the structure and intensity of university programs directly shape how much time, energy, and cognitive capacity students must allocate to their studies (Vokić et al., 2021). Across disciplines, compulsory elements such as laboratory work, practicum requirements, seminars, presentations, and continuous coursework create structured obligations that can limit students' ability to balance their studies with employment or personal routines. These pressures become particularly intense during examination periods, when multiple deadlines converge and academic expectations peak, creating periods in which maintaining balance might be especially challenging (Ashour et al., 2026; Akpen et al., 2024).

2.1.5.3 *Work-related Factors*

Similar to academic factors, work-related conditions represent an important determinant of students' WSLB, as job demands directly influence how much time and energy can realistically be devoted to other areas of life. The structure of student employment, including the predictability of shifts, autonomy over scheduling, and the intensity of daily tasks, shapes how effectively students coordinate responsibilities across different roles (Callender, 2008; Verma et al., 2024). Beyond time constraints, the qualitative aspects

of work also play an important role. Jobs involving emotional labor, customer-facing interactions, or sustained concentration may reduce students' cognitive readiness for academic tasks after work (Zhou et al., 2025).

2.1.5.4 Environmental and Social Factors

Environmental and social factors represent external conditions that can either support or hinder students' ability to maintain balance. At the micro level, everyday life is shaped by the interaction between unavoidable responsibilities and personal choices. Domestic obligations, such as household maintenance, child or eldercare, often place considerable demands on students' time and mental resources (Kaur & Pooja, 2019). However, this domain also involves the student's personal pursuits, including hobbies, physical exercise, and leisure activities, which prevent burnout (Gaur & Tarkar, 2025).

The quality of social relationships also plays an important role. Supportive relationships with partners, family members, friends, classmates, or colleagues can help buffer the stress associated with demanding schedules (Wong et al., 2021). This support may also come from the university environment itself, where institutional factors such as accessible academic advisors or flexible deadlines can reduce tension between work and study responsibilities (Rinki & Nadal, 2024).

At the macro level, broader social and economic conditions shape the realities of student life. Cultural norms often influence how students prioritize their responsibilities (Zaitouni et al., 2024). Economic pressures also play a significant role, as financial demands or fear of debt may force students to work long hours alongside their studies (Callender, 2008).

2.1.5.5 Technological Factors

In the modern era, technology plays an important role in WSLB, as it can both support and hinder balance. For working students, digital tools such as video conferencing platforms and collaborative software provide greater flexibility in combining multiple roles. However, technology also contributes to a phenomenon known as *techno-invasion* (Perera, 2021). Constant connectivity through smartphones and portable devices often creates an *always-on culture* (Mikołajczyk et al., 2023). As a result, receiving work emails or academic notifications during leisure time can prevent psychological detachment and mental recovery (McDowall & Kinman, 2017).

2.2 Well-being in the Context of Work–Study–Life Balance

2.2.1 Conceptualizing Well-being

Well-being is commonly understood as a dynamic state in which individuals are able to manage everyday demands, develop their potential, and maintain meaningful social relationships (Wentzel, 2024). Researchers emphasize that well-being is shaped by psychological, social, and contextual factors that interact throughout different stages of life (Pszczolinska, Mavor & Miles, 2025).

Theoretical approaches to well-being are generally divided into two complementary traditions, *hedonic and eudaimonic*. The hedonic perspective, rooted in subjective well-being theory, focuses on positive emotions, low negative affect, and overall life satisfaction as indicators of a good life (Svobodová, 2022). However, this form of well-being tends to fluctuate depending on current experiences and circumstances, which is especially common among university students exposed to academic and work-related stress (Worsley, Pennington & Corcoran, 2022). In contrast, the eudaimonic perspective emphasizes deeper aspects of human functioning, including meaning, autonomy, personal growth, and self-realization. Rather than focusing on temporary emotional states, it highlights whether individuals perceive their lives as purposeful and aligned with their personal values. This dimension of well-being is often associated with resilience, identity and the ability to cope with major life transitions (Svobodová, 2022; Wentzel, 2024).

Contemporary approaches therefore combine both perspectives and understand well-being as a multidimensional concept involving emotional, psychological, and social functioning (Svobodová, 2022). Seligman's well-being theory similarly describes well-being as a combination of multiple interconnected dimensions that together contribute to human flourishing (Seligman, 2011).

This multidimensional perspective is particularly relevant in the context of university students, whose lives are characterized by transition, identity development, and multiple overlapping roles (Douwes et al., 2023). Students often balance academic responsibilities, employment, and personal life while simultaneously building social relationships and future career paths (Wentzel, 2024). These demands may increase vulnerability to stress and anxiety, but they can also support personal growth and resilience (Pszczolinska, Mavor & Miles, 2025).

2.2.2 WSLB and Student Well-being

The relationship between WSLB and well-being is described in literature as asymmetrical and predominantly unidirectional. Thus, WSLB functions as the primary determinant of both mental and physical well-being, whereas the reverse influence, well-being shaping balance, is secondary and considerably weaker (Yusuf et al., 2020). This framing positions WSLB as a foundational condition that shapes how students experience academic, work, and personal demands, rather than as an outcome of their mental state (Prasad et al., 2025).

WSLB influences well-being by providing the structural and psychological stability necessary for students to manage multiple roles without experiencing chronic overload. When students maintain a coherent and predictable distribution of responsibilities, they preserve the cognitive and emotional resources required for healthy functioning (Dumanhog & Caliba, 2025). Conversely, Hendriks (2020) stresses that when balance deteriorates, students lose the capacity to recover between demands, which leads to cumulative fatigue, reduced emotional regulation, and heightened vulnerability to stress. This suggests that students with similar workloads may experience different levels of well-being. Rather than the objective level of demands, it is the perceived presence or absence of balance that shape psychological outcomes (El-Qebaisi, 2025).

As Dave (2018) notes, the link between WSLB and well-being is shaped by several psychological processes. Perceived role fit reduces internal tension and strengthens feelings of competence, while perceived control over time enhances autonomy, a core component of well-being, and enables students to regulate their commitments in ways that prevent overload (El-Qebaisi, 2025). In addition, time adequacy, understood as the subjective sense of having sufficient time for essential activities, reduces stress and supports emotional stability (Dumanhog & Caliba, 2025). Alignment with personal priorities further ensures that students' daily activities reflect their values, thereby increasing meaning, motivation, and long-term satisfaction (Yusuf et al., 2020). Each of these mechanisms contributes uniquely to well-being, making WSLB a multidimensional predictor rather than a single behavioral factor.

Lastly, as implied by Marecki (2024), WSLB also functions as a mediator between role demands and well-being outcomes. High academic or work demands do not necessarily lead to lower well-being, as their impact depends on the extent to which students are able

to maintain balance while meeting them. When WSLB is well maintained, demanding roles may be experienced as manageable or even growth-enhancing. However, when balance is disrupted, even moderate demands can contribute to stress, emotional exhaustion, and reduced academic engagement (Marecki, 2024). This mediating role helps explain why WSLB is often identified as a stronger predictor of mental health than demographic or situational variables in student populations (Hendriks, 2020).

2.2.3 Lifestyle Patterns

Daily lifestyle patterns including time allocation, sleep routines, or engagement in leisure form a multidimensional system that significantly shapes students' psychological resilience and academic functioning.

2.2.3.1 *Time Allocation and Management*

Time allocation is widely understood as a self-regulatory process that enables individuals to organize and prioritize daily activities in ways that support goal attainment and reduce stress. As McDonald and Hatcher (2022) note, students who structure their time effectively tend to experience greater cognitive clarity, lower emotional overload, and stronger academic persistence. By reducing uncertainty and preventing the accumulation of unfinished tasks, structured time enhances emotional resilience and allows students to distribute cognitive effort more evenly throughout the day. This also contributes to healthier routines in other lifestyle domains, including sleep and recovery (Patzak, 2025). In addition, effective time management is also closely linked to higher levels of self-control and study engagement, while simultaneously reducing mobile phone dependence, a factor known to undermine concentration (Fu et al., 2025).

2.2.3.2 *Sleep Hygiene*

Sleep is a fundamental biological process that supports memory, attention, and emotional regulation, all of which are essential for effective learning. Among university students, however, several lifestyle patterns commonly interfere with healthy sleep (Hyndych et al., 2025). Evening exposure to blue light from smartphones and computers delays melatonin release and disrupts circadian rhythms, while irregular bedtimes shaped by academic demands, part-time work, or social schedules further destabilize sleep–wake regulation, often resulting in increased daytime sleepiness. In shared living environments,

students may also struggle to maintain optimal sleep conditions such as darkness, quietness, or a cool room (Stores et al., 2023).

When sleep is compromised in this way, its cognitive and emotional consequences become evident. The hippocampus cannot effectively encode or consolidate new information without adequate NREM and REM sleep, which reduces learning capacity and accelerates forgetting. Attention also becomes less stable, as sleep-restricted students show slower reaction times, more lapses in vigilance, and reduced cognitive control (Hyndych et al., 2025). Emotional functioning is similarly affected. As indicated by Mutinský (2024), there is a clear link between elevated stress levels and poorer sleep quality, suggesting that inadequate sleep amplifies psychological strain (Hershner & Chervin, 2014).

2.2.3.3 *Leisure Time*

Leisure time is essential for sustaining well-being, especially for students who often navigate high academic pressure and irregular routines. Rather than being perceived as empty free time, leisure represents a meaningful space in which individuals restore energy, regulate emotions, and maintain long-term psychological and physical balance (Patzak, 2025). Importantly, leisure is not only restorative but also protective, as it can buffer the negative effects of academic strain, reduce the risk of burnout, and promote a more sustainable rhythm of study and recovery (Govindasamy et al., 2025).

Engaging in enjoyable, voluntary activities, whether creative, social, or physically active, supports mental resilience by activating psychological, social, and biological mechanisms that help prevent emotional overload and chronic fatigue (Fancourt et al., 2021). For adolescents and young adults, physical activity in particular has been linked to improved mood, stronger coping abilities, and a more positive sense of self (Lenze et al., 2025). Creative and expressive practices such as drawing, writing, or music similarly provide opportunities for self-reflection and emotional processing, offering an accessible form of support beyond formal mental health services. The social dimension of leisure, including spending time with peers, sharing experiences, and cultivating friendships, further enhances well-being by strengthening belonging and emotional connection (Borovica et al., 2024).

2.2.4 Consequences of WSLB Imbalance

2.2.4.1 *Psychological Consequences*

The most frequently observed psychological consequences include elevated perceived stress, anxiety, and a growing sense of emotional exhaustion (Anastasya et al., 2026). When students are unable to meet competing academic, work, and personal demands, they often feel overwhelmed and inadequate, which gradually reduces their ability to cope effectively (Rožman et al., 2025). Prolonged imbalance contributes to burnout, particularly its emotional component, which results from the depletion of cognitive and emotional resources needed for sustained academic engagement (Zhang & Wen, 2025).

These reactions are intensified when recovery time is insufficient, leading to irritability, frustration, and reduced emotional regulation. Under sustained strain, coping strategies tend to shift from *adaptive forms* such as planning and problem-solving to *maladaptive forms* such as avoidance, withdrawal, or procrastination, further increasing negative affect (Córdova et al., 2023).

As stress accumulates, students experience reduced motivation, cognitive overload, and concentration difficulties, all of which undermine emotional stability and well-being (Chidi-Belonwu, 2024). The Yerkes–Dodson law suggests that while moderate stress may enhance performance, excessive or chronic stress impairs learning, memory consolidation, and decision-making (Storbeck & Clore, 2008). When these conditions persist, psychological strain intensifies, increasing vulnerability to depressive symptoms and broader mental health decline (Chidi-Belonwu, 2024).

2.2.4.2 *Physiological Consequences*

WSLB imbalance also places substantial physiological strain on students, gradually disrupting the body's ability to maintain equilibrium (Hernandez et al., 2018). Persistent overload activates chronic stress responses, triggering sustained nervous system arousal and elevated cortisol levels, which is identified by Borowiec and Drygas (2023) as a key mechanism linking imbalance to deteriorating physical health. Over time, this prolonged activation of stress hormones can impair autonomic regulation and manifest in symptoms such as muscle tension, neck and back pain, tension headaches, and increased susceptibility to migraines (McCloughen et al., 2016).

Moreover, students frequently report gastrointestinal discomfort as well, as chronic stress affects gut motility and increases inflammatory responses, contributing to nausea, stomach cramps, and irritable bowel-like symptoms (Borowiec & Drygas, 2023). At the same time, academic and work pressures are often associated with irregular eating patterns, appetite fluctuations, and reliance on energy-dense convenience foods, which further affect metabolic functioning (Heinz et al., 2024)

Chronic stress additionally elevates blood pressure, increases HRV instability, and contributes to low-grade systemic inflammation representing factors associated with long-term cardiometabolic risk (Rožman et al., 2025). Reduced physical activity, another common consequence of overload, accelerates declines in cardiovascular fitness and contributes to weight gain or loss of muscle mass (Heinz et al., 2024; Hernandez et al., 2018). These patterns reflect what McCloughen et al. (2016) describe as the early emergence of metabolic disturbances among young adults experiencing psychological strain, including reduced energy, impaired glucose regulation, and heightened fatigue. Lastly, Doan et al. (2022) demonstrate that declines in physical health significantly reduce mental health scores, highlighting how stress-related physical strain amplifies emotional distress.

2.2.5 Mental Health Service Use Among Students

The utilization of mental health services among university students is consistently described as limited, even though the university period represents a developmental stage marked by heightened vulnerability to the onset or worsening of mental health difficulties (Holden et al., 2025). Students experiencing high stress, anxiety, or depressive symptoms often do not seek professional support, despite the availability of services designed to address these concerns (Osborn et al., 2022).

Research suggests that this gap between need and utilization is shaped not only by symptom severity but also by students' willingness to seek help. Many students express ambivalence toward professional support, preferring to manage problems independently or questioning the usefulness of available services (Ebert et al., 2019). Although students who perceive their symptoms as serious are more likely to consider professional help, many do not translate this perceived need into actual service use (Auty et al., 2022).

A range of barriers contributes to this gap between need and utilization. One of the most prominent is **stigma**, which encompasses both internalized beliefs and anticipated negative reactions from others. Students often fear being judged, misunderstood, or perceived as weak or unstable if they seek help, which significantly reduces their likelihood of engaging with professional services (Osborn et al., 2022). In some cultural contexts, stigma is even more pronounced (Kokosadze & Lortkipanidze, 2023).

Another important barrier is **financial accessibility**. Concerns about the cost of therapy, medication, or consultations are common, particularly in systems where mental health care is not fully covered (Ebert et al., 2019). These concerns may be notably salient for students from lower socioeconomic backgrounds (Kokosadze & Lortkipanidze, 2023).

Time-related and organizational constraints also limit students' ability to engage with mental health services. Academic and work responsibilities often leave little flexibility for scheduling appointments, making it difficult to seek help (Vokić et al., 2021). Moreover, long waiting periods and the limited capacity of counseling centers further reduce students' access to timely care (Osborn et al., 2022).

Finally, **information and awareness barriers** undermine help-seeking by limiting students' understanding of what services exist, how to access them, and what to expect from professional support. When services are poorly promoted, insufficiently integrated into campus communication channels, or described in vague or overly clinical terms, students may struggle to identify them as relevant or approachable resources (Cooper Russell et al., 2024).

2.3 Cultural Contexts of Work–Study–Life Balance

Culture is commonly defined in sociology and anthropology as a system of shared meanings, norms, and practices that shape how individuals interpret the world and behave within it (Raef et al., 2020). Rather than functioning as a static background variable, it is a dynamic and continuously evolving process embedded in everyday interactions, institutional structures, and social expectations (Miller et al., 2020).

In the context of WSLB, culture provides an interpretive framework through which individuals understand their responsibilities, evaluate competing demands, and judge what constitutes appropriate or desirable behavior (Walter & Matar, 2024). Cultural norms influence how people define social roles such as being a *good student* or a *dedicated employee* and determine which life domains are prioritized or deprioritized over others (Vokić et al., 2021). Culture thus operates as a macro-level determinant of WSLB. It structures expectations, legitimizes certain coping strategies, and shapes how individuals evaluate their own success or failure in balancing work, study, and personal life (Spencer-Oatey & Žegarac, 2018).

2.3.1 Cultural Frameworks Relevant to WSLB

Several theoretical frameworks help explain how cultural values and norms shape individuals' approaches to work, study, and personal life. For the purposes of this thesis, the author has chosen to focus on Hofstede's cultural dimensions and the Tightness–Looseness model.

2.3.1.1 Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions

Hofstede's cultural dimensions represent one of the most widely used frameworks for understanding cross-cultural differences relevant to WSLB. The model identifies several value dimensions that help explain how behavioral patterns vary across societies (Hofstede, 2011). The most relevant dimensions for this thesis are selected below:

Individualism versus Collectivism (I-C)

The I-C dimension captures the extent to which societies prioritize personal autonomy or group interdependence. In individualistic societies, personal autonomy, self-expression, and the pursuit of individual goals are strongly emphasized. Within such environments, students and workers often feel more justified in protecting their personal time,

negotiating workload boundaries, and prioritizing self-development (Lewis & Beauregard, 2018). Achievement is typically understood as the result of personal effort, and success is evaluated through individual accomplishment (Wieczorek-Szymańska, 2025). In contrast, collectivistic societies place greater importance on social roles, interdependence, and maintaining harmony within the group (Cheng, Rizkallah & Narizhnaya, 2020). Individuals are expected to fulfil obligations toward family or community. In these settings, achievement is frequently understood not only as a personal outcome but as a contribution to collective well-being (Wieczorek-Szymańska, 2025).

Power Distance (PDI)

PDI dimension refers to the degree to which hierarchical relationships and unequal power distributions are accepted within society. In high PDI cultures, authority figures such as supervisors, professors, or senior colleagues are rarely questioned, and individuals may hesitate to request flexibility or challenge unreasonable or excessive expectations. This dynamic can undermine the ability to negotiate a manageable workload or adapt schedules to personal needs. Conversely, low PDI cultures encourage participatory decision-making and open communication, making it more acceptable to discuss boundaries or express concerns about overload (Yu, Lee & Na, 2022).

Masculinity versus Femininity (MAS)

The MAS examines the extent to which societies value competitiveness, achievement, and assertiveness, traits typically associated with masculine values, versus cooperation, care, and quality of life, which are linked to feminine values (Żemojtel Piotrowska & Piotrowski, 2023).

In more masculine cultures, success is closely associated with high performance and visible accomplishment, which can intensify pressure on students and workers to excel, sometimes at the expense of well-being (Bolton, Pruzinsky & Stern, 2020). Feminine cultures, by contrast, prioritize interpersonal relationships, work–life balance, and collective well-being, making it more acceptable to rest, seek help, or set limits on workload (Agodzo, 2014). This dimension also shapes societal attitudes toward stress and the legitimacy of self-care, influencing whether emotional expression and help-seeking are encouraged or discouraged (Spencer-Oatey & Žegarac, 2018). Such cultural norms ultimately affect how individuals interpret burnout and whether they seek support (Bond & Smith, 2018).

Indulgence versus Restraint (IVR)

The IVR dimension concerns the degree to which societies permit the gratification of desires related to enjoyment and leisure. In societies where hard work is morally valorized, people often feel compelled to prioritize productivity even at the expense of well-being, whereas cultures that place greater value on leisure tend to legitimize rest as an essential component of a balanced life (Bolton, Pruzinsky & Stern, 2020).

Therefore, indulgent cultures encourage individuals to pursue pleasure, relaxation, and personal fulfilment, which can support healthier approaches to balancing work, study, and leisure. Restrained cultures, on the other hand, emphasize self-discipline, duty, and the suppression of personal desires, often positioning leisure as secondary to productivity. As a result, individuals may deprioritize rest or experience guilt when engaging in non-obligatory activities (Szegedi, Győri & Juhász, 2024).

2.3.1.2 Cultural Tightness–Looseness

Gelfand’s concept of cultural tightness–looseness provides an additional lens for understanding how societies regulate behavior (Aktas et al., 2015). Tight cultures maintain strong social norms and impose clear sanctions for deviation, resulting in high conformity and limited behavioral flexibility. Loose cultures tolerate a wider range of behaviors and allow individuals greater freedom to negotiate expectations (Gelfand et al., 2006).

This distinction is directly relevant to WSLB. In tight cultures, strict norms regarding academic performance, work discipline, or social roles can intensify pressure and reduce individuals’ ability to adjust their routines when demands become overwhelming. Loose cultures, by contrast, offer more space for individualized coping strategies, flexible scheduling, and alternative pathways to success (Walter & Matar, 2024).

As such, tightness–looseness complements Hofstede’s dimensions by highlighting the normative strength and enforcement mechanisms that shape everyday decision-making around work, study, and personal life (Aktas et al., 2015).

2.3.2 Work–Study–Life Balance in South Korea

2.3.2.1 Confucian Heritage

Confucianism has served as one of the most enduring ethical and philosophical foundations of Korean society, shaping its social structures, interpersonal norms, and collective mentality from the Joseon dynasty (dated 1392–1897) to the present (Chung, 2015). As Śleziak (2014) argues, Confucianism functions not as an explicit ideology but as an “*internalized, underlying ethnolinguistic system*” that subtly determines communication patterns, social expectations and interpersonal relationships (p. 212).

Confucian principles form the core of Korea’s traditional moral framework and were historically expressed through the Five Cardinal Relationships: *parent and child, ruler and subject, husband and wife, elder and younger, and friend and friend* (Śleziak, 2013). These relationships established clear expectations regarding hierarchy and appropriate behavior, with age and seniority remaining key markers of status (Górska-Szymczak & Machowski, 2022). Beyond interpersonal relations, Confucianism also shapes Korea’s collectivist orientation. Its emphasis on harmony, shared responsibility, and fulfilling one’s social role fosters a strong sense of belonging and mutual obligation. Thus, cooperation and social cohesion are often valued above individual autonomy, reinforcing the expectation that personal actions should contribute to the stability and well-being of the wider community. This collectivist ethos is reflected in family dynamics, workplace culture, and civic behavior (Chung, 2015).

Modernization has not displaced Confucianism in South Korea, instead, it has generated hybrid forms that integrate traditional values with contemporary economic and political structures. The country’s rapid development is often described as a form of *Confucian capitalism*, in which hierarchical discipline and collective loyalty coexist with market-driven efficiency and global competitiveness (Kim & Hamilton-Hart, 2017). At the same time, Confucianism has been increasingly challenged in contemporary South Korea, particularly in debates surrounding gender equality and individual autonomy. These discussions suggest that the tradition is being critically reassessed rather than simply accepted. Nevertheless, Confucianism continues to endure as a significant moral reference point for many Koreans (Chung, 2015).

2.3.2.2 *Academic and Work Culture in South Korea*

South Korea's education and work culture are closely linked to Confucian ideals, where discipline, achievement, and self-cultivation are not merely personal aspirations, but moral obligations tied to social expectations and family honor (Lee, 2020). Therefore, professional success functions as a central marker of social value, embedding competition into everyday life from an early age and shaping how individuals understand both personal worth and social responsibility (Yon, Jo, & Kim, 2023).

This cultural foundation is most visibly expressed in what scholars describe as South Korea's *education fever*, a society-wide phenomenon characterized by intense parental investment and early academic competition (Jeon, 2025). Educational advantages begin in early childhood with nearly 47.6% of children under six already attending *Hagwon*, private cram schools (Dyvik, 2025). As students move through the school system, these pressures do not simply persist but intensify into intensive study regimes. Daily routines extend well beyond formal school hours, incorporating afternoon tutoring and evening self-study (Jarvis et al., 2020). This pattern reaches its peak during preparation for the *Suneung*, the national university entrance exam, when students sacrifice rest, leisure, and social life in pursuit of scores seen as decisive for their future opportunities (Jeon, 2025). Consequently, South Korea consistently achieves strong educational outcomes, ranking highly in international assessments and having one of the world's highest tertiary attainment rates, with around 70% of young adults completing university education (OECD, 2024). This success, however, coexists with significant psychological strain, revealing a core tension within Korean society where high academic performance often entails substantial emotional and physical costs (Choi et al., 2019).

Notably, the norms cultivated within the educational system carry over into the workplace where dedication is demonstrated through endurance and constant availability, ultimately reinforcing a continuous cycle between educational and professional life (Kang, 2020). Currently, South Korea remains among the OECD countries with the longest working hours, as strong cultural expectations still emphasize long workdays, attendance, and collective commitment despite formal limits (ILO, 2022). Although a 40-hour work week has been introduced in the country, overtime is still common, with studies showing that employees often work very long weeks, sometimes reaching up to 68 hours (Kim. et al., 2023). In addition, traditional workplace norms are reinforced through strong hierarchical

structures. Employees are often expected to participate in after-work gatherings and maintain deference toward senior colleagues, making refusal or disagreement with superiors socially and professionally difficult (Low & Chua, 2019).

2.3.3 Work–Study–Life Balance in the Czech Republic

2.3.3.1 *European Humanist Values*

European humanism provides a normative framework that places the individual at the center of moral and social life, emphasizing dignity, autonomy, and the cultivation of personal potential (Ivić, 2019). Rooted in Renaissance and Enlightenment traditions, this orientation promotes self-reflection, rational agency, and the pursuit of a meaningful life, principles later embedded in the EU's legal-political value system (Akaliyski et al., 2022). In theory, these values support a model of autonomy that encourages individuals to shape their own trajectories while participating sensibly in society (Gobel et al., 2018).

Central European value orientations, including those in Czech society, draw on this humanistic legacy but are also shaped by the region's complex historical experiences, such as post-communist transitions, economic restructuring, and shifting social expectations (Krasnova & Grinavica, 2024). Hence, autonomy is often linked to responsibility, discipline, and achievement. This contributes to a cultural environment where personal development is valued, yet frequently measured through performance, productivity, and success (Akaliyski et al., 2022).

Accordingly, a tension emerges between humanistic ideals and everyday realities. While European humanism promotes balance, well-being, and personal development, individuals are still shaped by strong productivity norms, competitive educational environments, and increasing expectations for academic and professional performance (Polak & Rohs, 2023). These pressures may undermine the very autonomy and balance that humanistic values aim to cultivate (Gobel et al., 2018).

2.3.3.2 *Academic and Work Culture in the Czech Republic*

The Czech Republic's education and work environment reflects a cultural preference for moderation and personal autonomy, yet students and workers encounter pressures that complicate the pursuit of a balanced life. Although Czech society does not impose the

same moralized expectations around achievement seen in East Asian contexts, academic and economic demands still shape students' daily routines and influence their well-being (Majerová & Sokolová, 2025).

Academic expectations begin early in secondary school, where students face demanding curricula and competitive entrance requirements for selective programs, contributing to rising stress levels during transitional periods (Hauschildt et al., 2024). Although the Czech system is less hierarchical and less exam-centric than East Asian models, students still report substantial time pressure, especially during exam seasons, when procrastination, workload accumulation, and self-management difficulties intensify (Muja et al., 2024).

Working during studies is widely normalized, with nearly half of Czech and Slovak students employed alongside their coursework, most often in part-time or flexible roles that allow them to combine income generation with academic responsibilities (Hauschildt et al., 2019). This employment supports financial independence but also contributes to cumulative strain, particularly as living costs continue to rise. Students frequently report that balancing shifts with deadlines reduces their capacity for rest and recovery, mirroring broader European trends in which study–work incompatibility is a key predictor of lower well-being (Muja et al., 2024). The tension between autonomy and productivity becomes especially visible during peak academic periods, when students experience reduced functionality and heightened exam anxiety (Majerová & Sokolová, 2025). On the other hand, family expectations regarding academic achievement tend to be moderate, and students generally enjoy freedom in shaping their educational paths (Hauschildt, 2019).

Although Czech workplaces place less emphasis on formal authority than those in East Asia, norms learned during education, such as quiet diligence, self-reliance, and steady performance, carry over into professional life and shape expectations around reliability and adaptability (Blábol, 2022). Employees are often valued for their willingness to “get things done” which can translate into informal pressure to stay longer during busy periods or take on extra tasks (Guillén, 2021). Additionally, according to OECD (2024), Czech employees work roughly 1800 hours annually, placing the country above the EU average and well above countries such as Germany or the Netherlands.

3 METHODOLOGY

Research presented in this diploma thesis was partially conducted during the author's exchange study program at Pukyong National University in South Korea in 2025.

The thesis is structured into three main chapters: *the theoretical framework, methodology, and results*. The theoretical framework provides an overview of key concepts relevant to this study and draws on secondary literature. It examines work–study–life balance, the specific traits of student role systems, and the main factors influencing students' ability to manage multiple demands. The chapter also addresses well-being, lifestyle patterns and cultural context, forming a coherent theoretical foundation for empirical analysis.

The methodological chapter presents the research aim and questions, the research design, including the research instrument, as well as ethical and linguistic considerations that guided the study, and the use of AI tools. It additionally outlines the data collection process and the analytical approaches applied to the gathered material.

The empirical section presents and interprets the research findings. It includes descriptive and inferential analyses, supported where relevant by thematic interpretation. The results are discussed in relation to the theoretical framework introduced earlier, highlighting key patterns and implications for understanding students' work–life balance and well-being.

3.1 Research Design

The diploma thesis adopts a quantitative methodological approach, which is widely used in social sciences to examine patterns and relationships within larger populations. As Creswell (2014) notes, this approach allows researchers to identify measurable trends with a high level of reliability. Similarly, Foster et al. (2021) highlight that structured questionnaires are particularly effective for capturing attitudes, behaviors, and subjective perceptions in a standardized format.

The quantitative approach is applied within a comparative, cross-sectional research framework. The comparative design allows for systematic evaluation of differences between students in South Korea and the Czech Republic, while the cross-sectional design captures their experiences and perceptions at a single point in time.

3.1.1 Questionnaire Structure

Data for this research were collected through an online questionnaire created in Google Forms. The instrument consisted of a moderate number of items and included several question formats designed to capture both objective data and subjective evaluations.

The core of the questionnaire was based on five-point Likert scales ranging from 1 to 5 (1 = *Strongly disagree* to 5 = *Strongly agree*; in the case of stress-related items, 1 = *Not stressful at all* to 5 = *Very stressful*). In addition to scaled items, the questionnaire included closed-ended questions, numeric responses, and a small number of open-ended prompts, providing a combination of standardized measurement and exploratory insight.

The questionnaire was divided into six thematic sections, each addressing a specific dimension relevant to the research topic. The sections included the following:

- Demographic information
- Time allocation
- Work-study-life balance
- Well-being and stress
- Cultural and social perceptions
- Life satisfaction

Each section of the questionnaire addressed a different aspect of students' daily functioning and overall well-being. The opening section collected basic demographic characteristics of the respondents. The time allocation section examined how students distribute their time across study, work, personal activities, sleep, and household duties, as well as aspects of time management and organization. The WSLB section explored how academic and work responsibilities influence personal life, health, and relationships, including perceived energy levels. Well-being was assessed through items focusing on stress, emotional states, coping ability, and the use of mental health services. Cultural perceptions were measured using statements related to expectations of academic success, work ethic, and the influence of family and society. The final section assessed life satisfaction with work-life balance and invited respondents to reflect on potential improvements.

The instrument was developed specifically for this thesis, with its content and structure derived from the theoretical framework and research objectives. The sections were

designed independently by the researcher to capture both objective and subjective experiences of Czech and Korean university students. The aim was to construct a tool that accurately reflects the focus of the study, enabling meaningful cross-cultural comparison.

3.1.2 Language and Translation

During the part of the research conducted in South Korea, participants completed a Korean-language version of the questionnaire. The original English questionnaire, developed by the author, was translated into Korean in collaboration with two students from PKNU, Anna Denisova, BA in Korean Studies, and Shim Hee Jun, a student of International Relations, whose involvement ensured both linguistic accuracy and cultural appropriateness.

These colleagues also assisted in translating the gathered Korean responses back into English to enable data processing and analysis. For the Czech sample, a Czech-language version of the questionnaire was distributed. Both language versions of the instrument are provided in the Attachments.

3.1.3 Research Ethics

The research followed basic ethical standards for online questionnaire studies. Prior to participation, all respondents were informed about the purpose of the study and provided informed consent. Participation was voluntary and anonymous, and respondents could withdraw at any time without providing a reason. No personal or identifying data were collected, and no compensation was provided to participants. The study did not involve any foreseeable risks to respondents.

3.1.4 Use of AI Tools

Artificial intelligence tools were used in this thesis in accordance with *Dean's Regulation No. 1/2026 on the Use of Artificial Intelligence in Studies at FRDIS*. Gemini and Copilot were primarily used to support the writing process and improve the linguistic quality of the text, as English is not the author's native language. The tools also assisted in checking the clarity and coherence of longer passages and in exploring alternative ways of structuring or formulating certain ideas. However, the literature review, questionnaire design, data collection, statistical analysis, and interpretation of findings were carried out independently by the author.

3.2 Data Collection

3.2.1 Pukyong National University

The data collection process at PKNNU was carried out in two stages. The first stage took place during the author's exchange stay in the Republic of Korea and involved on-site data collection directly on the university campus. Between 10 June 2025 and 8 July 2025, the questionnaire was distributed online through the university's LMS system with the assistance of academic staff sharing the survey with students. To broaden participation, the author also promoted the questionnaire on campus using QR codes that were placed on information boards. Additional responses were obtained through direct one-to-one interactions with Korean students during social events.

The second stage of data collection was conducted later in the year. During this period, the questionnaire was distributed exclusively online through the university's LMS system by academic staff between 27 October 2025 and 4 December 2025, with 4 December 2025 serving as the submission deadline for responses.

3.2.2 Mendel University in Brno

The data collection process at Mendel University in Brno began on 5 November 2025, when the questionnaire was first distributed through social media platforms, including Facebook and Instagram. A second wave of distribution followed on 10 November 2025, when the author's thesis supervisor shared the survey with FRDIS students. Afterwards, the questionnaire remained open for responses. Another round of distribution took place on 11 December 2025, when additional FRDIS staff circulated the questionnaire online among students. The data collection period concluded on 8 January 2026.

3.3 Data Analysis

Once the responses were exported from Google Forms, the dataset was processed in Microsoft Excel, where variables were organized, recoded, and prepared for analysis. The dataset was subsequently imported into IBM SPSS Statistics, where several statistical methods were applied, including independent-samples t-tests, Spearman correlations, multiple regression analysis, and chi-square tests across the main analytical sections.

3.4 Aim of Research

The aim of this thesis is to examine how students in South Korea and the Czech Republic perceive and experience the balance between academic demands, work responsibilities, and personal life, and how this balance is associated with their well-being.

3.4.1 Research Questions and Hypotheses

This section presents research questions and corresponding null hypotheses. They are organized into five areas: *time allocation*, *work–study–life balance*, *well-being and stress*, *cultural and social perceptions and life satisfaction*.

TIME ALLOCATION

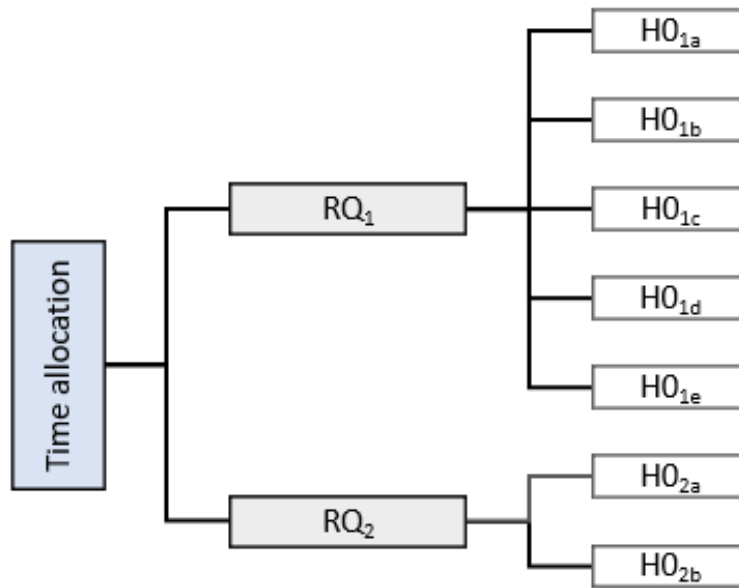
➤ **RQ1: How do Czech and Korean students allocate their time between study, work, personal life, sleep, and household duties?**

- H0_{1a}: There is no significant difference in study hours between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{1b}: There is no significant difference in work/internship hours between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{1c}: There is no significant difference in leisure/personal time between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{1d}: There is no significant difference in sleep duration between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{1e}: There is no significant difference in household or caregiving duties between Czech and Korean students.

➤ **RQ2: How do Czech and Korean students perceive their ability to manage their time across study, work, and personal life?**

- H0_{2a}: There is no significant difference in perceived time availability related to academic and work responsibilities between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{2b}: There is no significant difference in perceived ability to rest and recover between Czech and Korean students.

Figure 1 Overview of research questions and hypotheses for time allocation



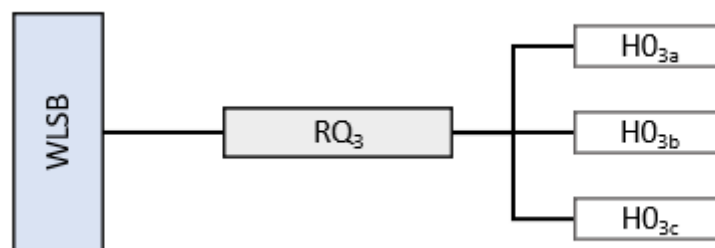
Source: own processing

WORK-STUDY-LIFE BALANCE

➤ **RQ₃: How do Czech and Korean students perceive the impact of study-work demands on their personal life, health, and relationships?**

- H0_{3a}: There is no significant difference in perceived impact on personal time between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{3b}: There is no significant difference in perceived impact on physical health between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{3c}: There is no significant difference in perceived impact on relationships between Czech and Korean students.

Figure 2 Overview of research question and hypotheses for work-study-life balance



Source: own processing

WELL-BEING AND STRESS

➤ RQ4: How do Czech and Korean students experience stress related to academic, work, financial, and social pressures?

- H0_{4a}: There is no significant difference in perceived academic stress between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{4b}: There is no significant difference in perceived work-related stress between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{4c}: There is no significant difference in perceived stress due to lack of personal time between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{4d}: There is no significant difference in perceived financial stress between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{4e}: There is no significant difference in perceived stress related to social expectations between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{4f}: There is no significant difference in perceived stress related to future uncertainty between Czech and Korean students.

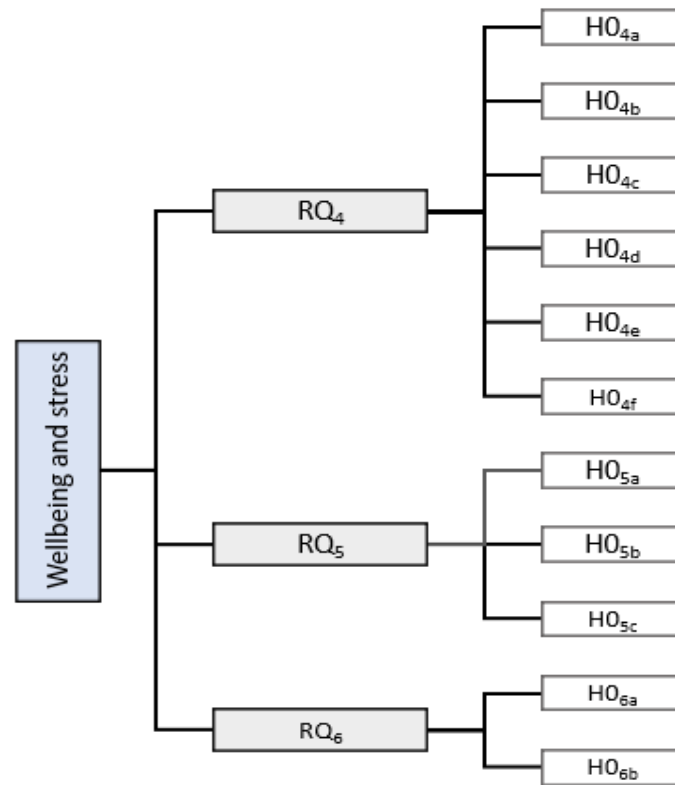
➤ RQ5: How do Czech and Korean students experience emotional well-being?

- H0_{5a}: There is no significant difference in emotional exhaustion between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{5b}: There is no significant difference in anxiety/overload between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{5c}: There is no significant difference in feelings of being unable to cope between Czech and Korean students.

➤ RQ6: What differences exist between Czech and Korean students in lifestyle-related well-being support and mental-health service use?

- H0_{6a}: There is no significant difference in perceived lifestyle support for mental well-being between Czech and Korean students.
- H0_{6b}: There is no significant difference in the use of mental-health services between Czech and Korean students.

Figure 3 Overview of research questions and hypotheses for wellbeing and stress



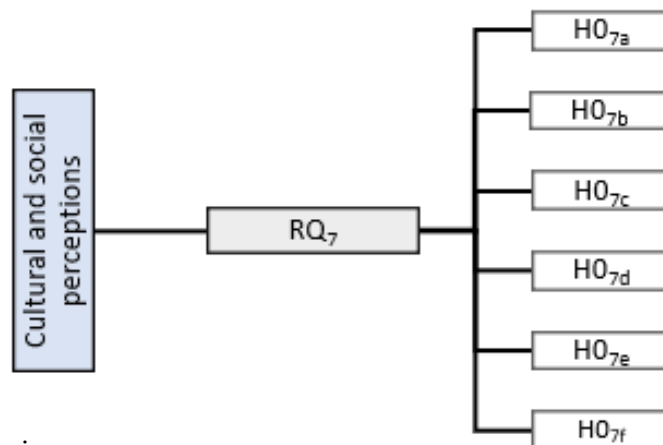
Source: own processing

CULTURAL AND SOCIAL PERCEPTIONS

➤ RQ7: How do Czech and Korean students perceive cultural and social norms related to academic success, work intensity, well-being, and family expectations?

- H07a: There is no significant difference between Czech and Korean students in the perception that academic/career success are prioritized over wellbeing.
- H07b: There is no significant difference between Czech and Korean students in the perception that success is judged mainly by grades or career status.
- H07c: There is no significant difference between Czech and Korean students in the perception that study/work hours are socially expected and limit free time.
- H07d: There is no significant difference between Czech and Korean students in the perception that wellbeing and rest are undervalued in their cultural environment.
- H07e: There is no significant difference between Czech and Korean students in the perception that family or social expectations influence academic or career decisions.

Figure 4 Overview of the research question and hypotheses for cultural perceptions



Source: own processing

LIFE SATISFACTION

➤ **RQ8: How satisfied are Czech and Korean students with their current balance between study, work, and personal life?**

- H0_{8a}: There is no significant difference in satisfaction with balance between Czech and Korean students.

Figure 5 Overview of the research question and hypothesis for life satisfaction



Source: own processing

4 RESULTS

4.1 Research Sample

Students from Mendel University in Brno and Pukyong National University were recruited for research. To be eligible, participants had to be enrolled at their university and simultaneously hold some form of employment, either part-time or full-time.

4.1.1 Korean Participants

A total of 328 students from PKNU participated in the online questionnaire. Of these respondents, 154 reported having some form of employment or internship. After data cleaning, 13 responses were removed due to incomplete answers, resulting in 141 valid responses included in the analytical part of the thesis.

Table 1 Demographic characteristics of Korean participants

Variables	Participants (N=141)
Gender, n (%)	
Male	63 (44.7)
Female	78 (55.3)
Age, n (%)	
19	8 (5.7)
20	15 (10.6)
21	32 (22.7)
22	29 (20.6)
23	24 (17.0)
24	5 (3.5)
≤ 25	28 (19.9)
Type of Study, n (%)	
Bachelor	103 (73)
Master	38 (27)
College, n (%)	
College of Humanities and Social Studies	42 (29.8)
College of Business Administration	27 (19.1)
College of Engineering	23 (16.3)
College of Fisheries Science	10 (7.1)
College of Environmental Technology	13 (9.2)
College of Natural Science	26 (18.4)

Source: own processing

Following Table 1, the ages of the participants ranged from 19 to 25 years, with the largest age group being 21-year-olds. Male students represented 45% of the sample, while female students accounted for 55%. Almost three-quarters of the participants were enrolled in bachelor's programs whereas slightly more than one-quarter were pursuing a master's degree. Participants were drawn from six of the eight colleges at PKNU. Most students majored in humanities, social or natural sciences or business, comprising nearly 67% of sample. The remaining 33% were enrolled in engineering and environmental programs.

4.1.2 Czech Participants

In total, 219 students from Mendel University completed the questionnaire. Of these, 83 reported having no form of employment and were therefore excluded from further analysis. After removing an additional four incomplete responses, the analytical sample consisted of 132 students who were either part/full time employed or interns.

Table 2 Demographic characteristics of Czech participants

Variables	Participants (N=132)
Gender, n (%)	
Male	43 (32.6)
Female	89 (67.4)
Age, n (%)	
20	9 (6.8)
21	24 (18.2)
22	17 (12.9)
23	36 (27.3)
24	25 (18.9)
≤ 25	21 (15.9)
Type of Study, n (%)	
Bachelor	60 (45.5)
Master	72 (54.5)
College, n (%)	
Faculty of Regional Development and International Studies	85 (64.4)
Faculty of Business and Economics	11 (8.3)
Faculty of Agrisciences	14 (10.6)
Faculty of Forestry and Wood Technology	18 (13.6)
Faculty of Horticulture	4 (3)

Source: own processing

The demographic characteristics of the Czech sample are shown in Table 2. Participants were aged between 20 and 25 years, with the most represented age group being 23-year-olds. As for the Korean sample, the age distribution corresponds to the typical age range of university students in both countries. Female students made up 67% of the sample, while male students accounted for 33%.

Unlike the Korean sample, the Czech group had a higher proportion of master's students, approximately 54% compared to 46% enrolled in bachelor's programs. Students from all Mendel University faculties took part in the study, with FRDIS students forming the majority (64%).

4.1.3 Employment Status

As part of the demographic section of the questionnaire, students were asked whether they were currently engaged in any form of paid or unpaid employment during their studies. Table 3 summarizes the employment status of all respondents from Mendel University and PKNU, with invalid or incomplete responses removed prior to classification. Altogether, 547 participants took part in the questionnaire.

Table 3 Employment status of Mendel and PKNU students (full sample)

Employment type	Mendel (N=215, %)	PKNU (N=315, %)
Total employed	132 (61.4%)	141 (44.8%)
Not employed	83 (38.6%)	174 (55.2%)

Source: own processing

The comparison of two student groups indicates notable disparities in their engagement in work alongside their studies. In the Czech sample, 61% of students reported having a work or internship, whereas in the Korean sample this applied to only 45% of respondents.

These differences suggest that Czech students are more likely to combine their studies with paid work, whereas a larger proportion of Korean students remain fully focused on their academic responsibilities.

To provide a clearer picture of students' work patterns, Table 4 presents the distribution of employment types calculated solely from respondents who indicated having a job or internship.

Table 4 Employment types among employed students (analytical sample)

Employment type	Mendel (N=132, %)	PKNU (N=141, %)
Part-time paid work	110 (83.3%)	77 (54.6%)
Full-time paid work	15 (11.4%)	8 (5.7%)
Part-time unpaid internship	3 (2.3%)	38 (27.0%)
Full-time unpaid internship	4 (3.0%)	18 (12.8%)

Source: own processing

The comparison between the two student groups indicates clear differences in employment patterns. Employment among Czech students was predominantly in paid part-time positions, which constituted 83% of all employed respondents. Full-time paid work represented 11%, while unpaid internships were relatively uncommon, together comprising just 5%. This distribution indicates that Czech students who work typically choose flexible, paid part-time roles that can be more easily balanced with academic obligations.

In contrast, Korean students displayed a more varied employment structure. Although 55% worked in paid part-time positions, a substantial proportion participated in unpaid internships, either part-time (27%) or full-time (13%). This may reflect the stronger emphasis placed on practical experience and résumé building as preparation for future employment.

4.2 Time Allocation

RQ₁ examined how Czech and Korean university students allocate their time across five key domains of daily functioning (Table 5). These variables provide a detailed picture of students' daily routines and allow a comparison between the two national groups.

Korean students showed a clear tendency to devote more hours to studying, with a mean of 6.60 hours per day compared to 5.62 hours per day among Czech students. In contrast, Czech students spent more time working or interning, averaging 4.25 hours per day, whereas Korean students report 3.28 hours per day. A similar pattern emerged for personal time and household duties, with Czech students reporting slightly more leisure time ($M = 3.56$) and substantially more time spent on domestic responsibilities ($M = 1.73$) than their Korean counterparts. Sleep duration was the most balanced domain, with both groups reporting a median of seven hours per day and only a minimal difference in mean values.

Table 5 Descriptive statistics of time allocation among Czech and Korean students

Variable	Country	Mean	Median	SD
STUDY	KR	6.60	7	1.756
	CZ	5.62	6	1.880
WORK/ INTERNSHIP	KR	3.28	3	1.741
	CZ	4.25	4	1.664
PERSONAL TIME	KR	3.10	3	1.40
	CZ	3.56	3	1.45
HOUSEHOLD DUTIES	KR	1.17	1	0.853
	CZ	1.73	2	0.818
SLEEP	KR	6.95	7	1.244
	CZ	7.08	7	1.146

Source: own processing

Table 6 further evaluates these differences using independent samples t-tests. Statistically significant group differences were found in four of the five domains, including study time, work/internship hours, personal time, and household duties.

Table 6 Group differences in time allocation between Czech and Korean students

Variable	t	MD	p	Cohen d
STUDY	4.460	+ 0.982	<0.001	0.540
WORK/INTERNSHIP	- 4.716	- 0.973	<0.001	- 0.571
PERSONAL TIME	2.70	+ 0.46	0.007	0.32
HOUSEHOLD DUTIES	- 5.573	- 0.565	<0.001	- 0.675
SLEEP	0.90	+ 0.13	0.37	0.11

Source: own processing

The largest effect was observed for study time ($p < 0.001$, $d = 0.540$), indicating substantially higher academic involvement among Korean students. Work and household duties also differed significantly, both with moderate effect sizes, reflecting greater work and domestic engagement among Czech students. Personal time showed a smaller but

still significant difference ($p = 0.007$, $d = 0.32$). Sleep was the only domain without a significant difference ($p = 0.37$, $d = 0.11$), suggesting comparable sleep duration across both groups.

Evaluation: The analysis revealed clear and statistically significant differences in how Czech and Korean students allocate their time. Korean students spent more hours per day studying, which led to the rejection of $H0_{1a}$, while Czech students devoted significantly more time to work or internships, resulting in the rejection of $H0_{1b}$. Czech students also reported more personal time, which rejected $H0_{1c}$, and more household duties, which rejects $H0_{1e}$. Sleep duration did not differ significantly between the groups, therefore $H0_{1d}$ was retained.

To answer RQ2, two variables of subjective time management were analyzed: *perceived time availability for academic and work responsibilities*, and *perceived ability to rest and recover*. Table 7 presents the descriptive statistics for both groups.

Table 7 Descriptive statistics of time management among Czech and Korean students

Variable	Country	Mean	Median	SD
Perceived time availability for study and employment	KR	2.74	3	1.125
	CZ	2.88	3	1.126
Perceived time ability to rest and recover	KR	2.18	2	1.044
	CZ	2.36	2	1.092

Source: own processing

Czech students reported slightly higher levels of perceived time availability ($M = 2.88$) compared to Korean students ($M = 2.74$). A similar pattern emerged for perceived ability to rest and recover, where Czech students again scored marginally higher ($M = 2.36$) than Korean students ($M = 2.18$). Although the differences were consistent in direction, their magnitude was small, suggesting that both groups experience comparable perceived time constraints and opportunities for rest.

To determine whether these differences were statistically significant, independent samples t-tests were conducted (Table 8). For perceived time availability, the difference between groups was not significant ($p = 0.301$). Similarly, perceived ability to rest and recover did not differ significantly between Czech and Korean students ($p = 0.168$). The effect sizes for both variables were small (Cohen's $d = -0.125$ for time availability;

d = - 0.167 for rest and recovery), further indicating that the observed differences were negligible in practical terms.

Table 8 Group differences in time management between Czech and Korean students

Variable	t	MD	p	Cohen d
Perceived time availability for study and employment	- 1.036	- 0.141	0.301	- 0.125
Perceived time ability to rest and recover	- 1.383	- 0.179	0.168	- 0.167

Source: own processing

To complement the group comparisons presented earlier, Spearman correlation analyses were conducted separately for Czech and Korean students to examine the relationship between objective time-allocation patterns and subjective perceptions of time management. The results are summarized in Table 9.

Table 9 Spearman correlations between time-allocation and subjective time-management among Czech and Korean students

Variable	Country	Perceived time availability for study and employment	Perceived rest ability
STUDY	KR	$\rho = - 0.285$ (p = 0.004)	$\rho = - 0.210$ (p = 0.028)
	CZ	$\rho = - 0.196$ (p = 0.024)	$\rho = - 0.150$ (p = 0.087)
WORK/ INTERNSHIP	KR	$\rho = - 0.041$ (p = 0.650)	$\rho = - 0.102$ (p = 0.240)
	CZ	$\rho = 0.011$ (p = 0.904)	$\rho = - 0.089$ (p = 0.309)
PERSONAL TIME	KR	$\rho = 0.188$ (p = 0.041)	$\rho = 0.301$ (p < 0.001)
	CZ	$\rho = - 0.065$ (p = 0.459)	$\rho = - 0.127$ (p = 0.148)
HOUSEHOLD DUTIES	KR	$\rho = - 0.022$ (p = 0.790)	$\rho = - 0.030$ (p = 0.720)
	CZ	$\rho = 0.073$ (p = 0.407)	$\rho = 0.097$ (p = 0.268)
SLEEP	KR	$\rho = 0.255$ (p = 0.006)	$\rho = 0.342$ (p < 0.001)
	CZ	$\rho = - 0.160$ (p = 0.067)	$\rho = - 0.239$ (p = 0.006)

Source: own processing

Among Czech students, study hours per day showed a small but statistically significant negative correlation with perceived time availability for study and employment ($\rho = -0.196$, $p = 0.024$), suggesting that a higher study load is associated with a reduced sense of having enough time. Sleep duration was also negatively correlated with perceived rest ability ($\rho = -0.239$, $p = 0.006$), indicating that shorter sleep was linked to a reduced sense of recovery. No other time-allocation variables were significantly related to subjective time-management indicators.

The Korean sample displayed similar, yet more pronounced patterns. Study hours per day showed a stronger negative association with perceived time availability ($\rho = -0.285$, $p = 0.004$), reflecting the heavier academic workload reported by Korean students. Personal time was significantly associated with both perceived time availability ($\rho = 0.188$, $p = 0.041$) and perceived rest ability ($\rho = 0.301$, $p < 0.001$), highlighting the central role of leisure time in subjective well-being among Korean students. Sleep again emerged as a strong positive predictor of perceived rest ability ($\rho = 0.342$, $p < 0.001$).

Evaluation: Despite substantial differences in objective time allocation, Czech and Korean students reported similar levels of perceived time availability for study and employment and perceived ability to rest. The absence of statistically significant differences supports the retention of $H0_{2a}$ and $H0_{2b}$, indicating that subjective time management is comparable across both groups. Correlation analysis further clarified these findings. In both countries, higher study load was associated with lower perceived time availability, while longer sleep supported better perceived rest ability.

4.3 Work-Study-Life Balance

RQ₃ examined how Czech and Korean university students perceive the impact of study–work demands on their personal time, health, and relationships. These domains capture the extent to which academic and work responsibilities interfere with everyday functioning and well-being.

Table 10 presents the descriptive statistics for all three domains of WSLB conflict. The results show that both groups report relatively high interference with personal time, with Korean students scoring $M = 3.96$ and Czech students $M = 4.16$. This suggests that time pressure is a common experience across both cultural contexts. More substantial differences appear in the perceived impact on physical and mental health. Korean students

reported a noticeably lower level of health-related strain ($M = 3.11$) compared to Czech students ($M = 3.91$). A similar pattern is observed for the impact on relationships, where Korean students again reported lower interference ($M = 3.13$) than Czech students ($M = 3.55$). These descriptive patterns indicate that Czech students may experience the broader consequences of study-work demands more intensely, particularly in health and relational domains.

Table 10 Descriptive statistics for WSLB conflict among Czech and Korean students

Variable	Country	Mean	Median	SD
PERSONAL TIME IMPACT	KR	3.96	4	0.840
	CZ	4.16	4	0.956
HEALTH IMPACT	KR	3.11	3	1.231
	CZ	3.91	4	1.066
RELATIONSHIPS IMPACT	KR	3.13	3	1.237
	CZ	3.55	4	1.231

Source: own processing

Table 11 summarizes the results of independent samples t-tests and largely confirms patterns exhibited in descriptive part. While the difference in personal time impact was not statistically significant ($p = 0.075$), Czech students reported significantly higher levels of health-related strain ($p < 0.001$, $d = 0.69$) and relationship interference ($p = 0.006$, $d = 0.33$). Effect sizes range from small to medium, suggesting that these differences are not only statistically significant but also practically meaningful, particularly in the domain of health.

Table 11 Group differences in WSLB conflict between Czech and Korean students

Variable	t	MD	p	Cohen d
Personal life impact	1.789	0.195	0.075	0.217
Health impact	5.691	0.796	<0.001	0.689
Relationships impact	2.797	0.418	0.006	0.330

Source: own processing

To further explore these dynamics, Spearman correlations were computed between time allocation and perceived personal time-related conflict. As presented in Table 12, study

hours were positively associated with perceived personal time impact among both Czech ($\rho = 0.345$, $p = 0.001$) and Korean students ($\rho = 0.231$, $p = 0.008$), indicating that increased study time is linked to stronger perceived interference with personal life.

Employment hours, however, showed different patterns across the two groups. Among Czech students, the relationship between employment hours and perceived personal time impact was not statistically significant ($\rho = -0.112$, $p = 0.210$). In contrast, Korean students showed a significant negative correlation between employment hours and personal time impact ($\rho = -0.256$, $p = 0.003$).

Table 12 Spearman correlations between time allocation and WSLB conflict among Czech and Korean students

Variable	Country	Personal time impact
Study hours	KR	$\rho = 0.231$ ($p = 0.008$)
	CZ	$\rho = 0.345$ ($p = 0.001$)
Employment hours	KR	$\rho = -0.256$ ($p = 0.003$)
	CZ	$\rho = -0.112$ ($p = 0.210$)

Source: own processing

Evaluation: Despite similar levels of perceived interference with personal time, which led to the retention of H_{03a} , Czech and Korean students differed markedly in how study-work demands affected their health and relationships, resulting in the rejection of H_{03b} and H_{03c} . Overall, while time pressure appeared comparable across groups, its spillover effect on health and relationships were more pronounced among Czech students.

4.4 Well-being and Stress

RQ₄ explored how Czech and Korean students experience stress across six domains relevant to student well-being and WSLB (listed in Tabel 13). These items were rated on a five-point scale ranging from 1 (“not stressful at all”) to 5 (“very stressful”).

Table 13 indicates distinct cross-national patterns in perceived stress. Korean students reported higher levels of stress in academically and socially oriented domains, including academic workload ($M = 4.11$ vs. 3.86), financial pressure ($M = 3.89$ vs. 3.64), social expectations ($M = 3.84$ vs. 2.95), and future uncertainty ($M = 3.48$ vs. 2.79). These patterns suggest stronger academic pressure, societal expectations, and future-related concerns among Korean students. In contrast, Czech students confirmed higher work-

related stress ($M = 3.32$ vs. 2.45), consistent with earlier findings indicating greater involvement in employment. Stress related to lack of personal time was comparable across groups, pointing to shared challenges in balancing study and work demands.

Table 13 Descriptive statistics of stress levels among Czech and Korean students

Variable	Country	Mean	Median	SD
Academic stress	KR	4.11	4	0.698
	CZ	3.86	4	0.789
Work stress	KR	2.45	2	0.841
	CZ	3.32	3	1.086
Lack of personal time stress	KR	3.54	4	0.937
	CZ	3.36	4	1.072
Financial stress	KR	3.89	4	0.957
	CZ	3.64	4	1.212
Social expectation stress	KR	3.84	4	1.080
	CZ	2.95	3	1.191
Future uncertainty stress	KR	3.48	4	1.230
	CZ	2.79	2	1.213

Source: own processing

Table 14 further examines these differences using independent samples t-tests, which largely confirm patterns observed in the descriptive statistics.

Table 14 Group differences in stress levels between Czech and Korean students

Variable	t	MD	p	Cohen d
Academic stress	- 2.775	- 0.250	0.006	- 0.336
Work stress	7.377	+ 0.864	<0.001	0.893
Lack of personal time stress	- 1.441	- 0.175	0.151	- 0.175
Financial stress	- 1.899	- 0.250	0.059	- 0.230
Social expectation stress	- 6.420	- 0.882	<0.001	- 0.778
Future uncertainty stress	- 4.629	- 0.687	<0.001	- 0.561

Source: own processing

As shown in Table 14, Korean students experienced significantly higher academic stress ($p = 0.006$, $d = -0.34$), social expectation stress ($p < 0.001$, $d = -0.78$), and stress related to future uncertainty ($p < 0.001$, $d = -0.56$). In contrast, Czech students displayed significantly higher work-related stress ($p < 0.001$, $d = 0.89$), representing the most pronounced difference between the groups. No statistically significant differences were observed for stress related to lack of personal time ($p = 0.151$) or financial pressure ($p = 0.059$), indicating comparable levels across countries.

Evaluation: The results reveal clear cross-national differences in several stress domains. Significantly higher levels of academic stress, social expectation stress, and future uncertainty among Korean students led to the rejection of $H0_{4a}$, $H0_{4e}$, and $H0_{4f}$, whereas higher work-related stress among Czech students resulted in the rejection of $H0_{4b}$. In contrast, no significant differences were found in stress related to personal time or financial pressure. Therefore, $H0_{4c}$ and $H0_{4d}$ were retained.

To address RQ₅, three variables of emotional well-being were examined including *emotional exhaustion*, *anxiety/overload*, and *perceived inability to cope*. These variables represent key aspects of students' emotional functioning and enable comparison between Czech and Korean respondents.

Table 15 Descriptive statistics of emotional wellbeing among Czech and Korean students

Variable	Country	Mean	Median	SD
Emotional exhaustion	KR	3.12	3	1.174
	CZ	3.48	4	1.182
Anxiety/overload	KR	3.89	4	1.094
	CZ	3.57	4	1.199
Perceived inability to cope	KR	2.62	2	1.033
	CZ	2.91	3	1.149

Source: own processing

Table 15 summarizes the descriptive statistics for three variables of emotional well-being among Czech and Korean students. The results show noticeable but moderate cross-national differences. Czech students registered higher emotional exhaustion ($M = 3.48$, $SD = 1.182$) compared to Korean students ($M = 3.12$, $SD = 1.174$), indicating a slightly greater tendency toward fatigue and emotional strain. Korean students,

however, scored higher on anxiety/overload ($M = 3.89$, $SD = 1.094$) relative to their Czech counterparts ($M = 3.57$, $SD = 1.199$), suggesting that feelings of tension and pressure are more prevalent in the Korean sample. For perceived inability to cope, Czech students again showed higher values ($M = 2.91$, $SD = 1.149$) than Korean students ($M = 2.62$, $SD = 1.033$), reflecting somewhat greater perceived difficulties in coping with demands.

Independent samples t-tests presented in Table 16 confirmed that these differences were statistically significant across all three indicators. Czech students reported significantly higher emotional exhaustion ($p = 0.013$, $d = 0.30$) and perceived inability to cope ($p = 0.028$, $d = 0.28$), whereas Korean students described significantly higher anxiety/overload ($p = 0.020$, $d = -0.28$).

Table 16 Group differences in emotional well-being between Czech and Korean students

Variable	t	MD	p	Cohen d
Emotional exhaustion	2.501	+ 0.357	0.013	0.303
Anxiety/overload	- 2.345	- 0.325	0.020	- 0.284
Inability to cope	2.212	+ 0.292	0.028	0.279

Source: own processing

To complement the group comparisons presented earlier, Spearman correlation analyses were conducted separately for Czech and Korean students to examine the associations between six stress domains and three variables of emotional well-being. Spearman's rho was applied due to the ordinal nature of the single-item Likert measures. The results are summarized in Table 17.

Among Czech students, significant correlations were observed primarily for academic stress, lack of personal time, and financial stress. Academic stress displayed small but significant correlations with anxiety ($\rho = 0.276$, $p < .001$) and perceived inability to cope ($\rho = 0.237$, $p = .006$). Lack of personal time demonstrated the strongest relationships across all well-being variables, particularly emotional exhaustion ($\rho = 0.496$, $p < .001$). Financial stress showed weak to moderate associations, particularly in the Czech sample, where significant correlations emerged for anxiety and coping difficulties. Social expectation stress and future uncertainty posed no meaningful correlations.

In the Korean sample, a different pattern emerged. Academic stress and social expectation stress displayed stronger and more consistent associations with emotional well-being, especially anxiety (academic: $\rho = 0.362$, $p < .001$; social expectations: $\rho = 0.412$, $p < .001$). Lack of personal time was significantly related to emotional exhaustion ($\rho = 0.388$, $p < .001$) and coping difficulties ($\rho = 0.251$, $p = .009$). In contrast, work stress has resulted in mixed results, with significant associations with emotional exhaustion in both groups but limited relationships with other outcomes. Future uncertainty confirmed small but notable correlations with emotional exhaustion ($\rho = 0.211$, $p = .028$) and anxiety ($\rho = 0.297$, $p = .003$).

Table 17 Spearman correlations between stress domains and emotional well-being among Czech and Korean students

Variable	Country	Emotional exhaustion	Anxiety/overload	Incapability to cope
Academic stress	KR	$\rho = 0.245$ ($p = 0.012$)	$\rho = 0.362$ ($p < 0.001$)	$\rho = 0.218$ ($p = 0.021$)
	CZ	$\rho = 0.214$ ($p = 0.014$)	$\rho = 0.276$ ($p < 0.001$)	$\rho = 0.237$ ($p = 0.006$)
Work stress	KR	$\rho = 0.341$ ($p < 0.001$)	$\rho = 0.142$ ($p = 0.118$)	$\rho = 0.081$ ($p = 0.331$)
	CZ	$\rho = 0.341$ ($p < 0.001$)	$\rho = 0.031$ ($p = 0.728$)	$\rho = 0.258$ ($p = 0.004$)
Lack of personal time stress	KR	$\rho = 0.388$ ($p < 0.001$)	$\rho = 0.067$ ($p = 0.402$)	$\rho = 0.251$ ($p = 0.009$)
	CZ	$\rho = 0.496$ ($p < 0.001$)	$\rho = 0.414$ ($p < 0.001$)	$\rho = 0.186$ ($p = 0.033$)
Financial stress	KR	$\rho = 0.128$ ($p = 0.152$)	$\rho = 0.179$ ($p = 0.064$)	$\rho = 0.097$ ($p = 0.268$)
	CZ	$\rho = 0.157$ ($p = 0.073$)	$\rho = 0.253$ ($p = 0.004$)	$\rho = 0.222$ ($p = 0.011$)
Social expectation stress	KR	$\rho = 0.301$ ($p = 0.002$)	$\rho = 0.412$ ($p < 0.001$)	$\rho = 0.284$ ($p = 0.004$)
	CZ	$\rho = 0.133$ ($p = 0.139$)	$\rho = 0.093$ ($p = 0.291$)	$\rho = 0.196$ ($p = 0.028$)
Future uncertainty stress	KR	$\rho = 0.211$ ($p = 0.028$)	$\rho = 0.297$ ($p = 0.003$)	$\rho = 0.167$ ($p = 0.072$)
	CZ	$\rho = 0.106$ ($p = 0.226$)	$\rho = 0.171$ ($p = 0.050$)	$\rho = 0.012$ ($p = 0.891$)

Source: own processing

Table 18 summarizes the results of two regression analyses examining the extent to which individual stress domains predict emotional exhaustion among Czech and Korean

university students. In both models, the dependent variable was a single Likert-type item measuring subjective emotional exhaustion.

Table 18 Regression for emotional exhaustion among Czech and Korean students

Variable	Country	b*	Std. Error	β	t	p
Academic stress	KR	0.230	0.115	0.255	2.005	0.048
	CZ	- 0.049	0.123	- 0.033	- 0.397	0.692
Work stress	KR	0.014	0.095	0.018	0.168	0.872
	CZ	0.224	0.085	0.206	2.642	0.009
Lack of personal time stress	KR	0.340	0.126	0.343	2.831	0.006
	CZ	0.545	0.108	0.495	5.041	<0.001
Financial stress	KR	0.066	0.091	0.078	0.723	0.471
	CZ	- 0.083	0.100	- 0.085	- 0.833	0.406
Social expectation stress	KR	0.210	0.107	0.225	2.146	0.038
	CZ	0.130	0.090	0.131	1.440	0.152
Future uncertainty stress	KR	0.069	0.092	0.070	0.671	0.505
	CZ	0.083	0.078	0.085	1.061	0.291

Source: own processing

The regression model for Czech students explained 27.3% of the variance in emotional exhaustion ($R^2 = 0.273$) and reached statistical significance. Two predictors emerged as significant, including work stress ($p = 0.009$; $\beta = 0.206$) and, most notably, lack of personal time ($p < 0.001$; $\beta = 0.495$). These findings indicate that emotional exhaustion among Czech students is primarily associated with employment demands and limited personal time. All other stressors were non-significant.

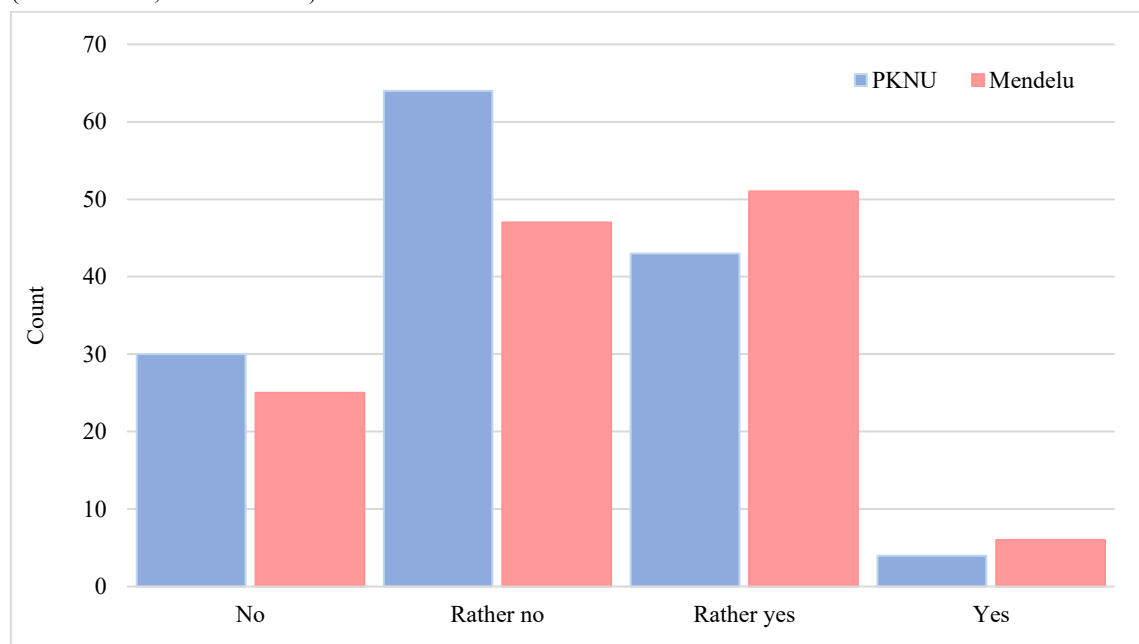
The regression model for Korean students explained 16.2% of the variance in emotional exhaustion ($R^2 = 0.162$), which is lower than in the Czech sample but still statistically significant ($p = 0.001$). Significant effects were observed for lack of personal time ($p = 0.006$; $\beta = 0.343$) and social expectation stress ($p = 0.038$; $\beta = 0.225$). Academic

stress ($p = 0.048$; $\beta = 0.255$) was also a significant but somewhat weaker predictor. Korean students' emotional exhaustion was primarily associated with limited personal time and social and academically driven pressures.

Evaluation: All three hypotheses (H_{05a} , H_{05b} , H_{05c}) were rejected, as significant differences were found between Czech and Korean students in all emotional well-being indicators. However, the effect sizes were small, indicating limited practical relevance of these differences. Correlation and regression analyses further suggest that emotional well-being is more strongly linked to specific stress domains, especially lack of personal time and academic-related stress.

In addressing RQ₆, the first step was to examine whether Czech and Korean students differ in their perceptions of the extent to which their current lifestyle supports their mental well-being. Responses were grouped into four categories ranging from “No” to “Yes,” and the distribution of these responses was compared between the two countries.

Figure 6 Perceived lifestyle support for wellbeing among Czech and Korean students
(PKNU_n = 141, Mendel_n = 129)



Source: own processing

Figure 6 indicates that both groups most frequently selected the middle categories (“Rather no” and “Rather yes”), while the extreme responses (“No” and “Yes”) were less common. Czech students tended to choose “Rather yes” slightly more often, whereas Korean students more frequently selected “Rather no.” However, these differences were relatively small.

For the Mendel University sample, 129 responses were included in the comparison. Three additional students chose the “Other” option, and their comments did not match the predefined categories. These students mentioned, for example, that their lifestyle feels stressful but worthwhile for future goals, or that their sense of well-being varies depending on exam periods and personal workload.

A chi-square test was conducted to statistically assess whether the distribution of responses differed between the two countries. As shown in Table 19, the association between country and perceived lifestyle support for mental well-being was not statistically significant ($\chi^2 = 3.613$, $df = 3$, $p = 0.306$). This suggests that Czech and Korean students report broadly similar patterns in how supportive they perceive their lifestyle to be for their mental well-being.

Table 19 Perceived lifestyle support among students (Chi-Square Test)

Lifestyle support for well-being	CZ (n = 129)	KR (n = 141)
No	25 (19.4%)	30 (21.3%)
Rather no	47 (36.4%)	64 (45.4%)
Rather yes	51 (39.5%)	43 (30.5%)
Yes	6 (4.7%)	4 (2.8%)
Chi-Square (χ^2)	3.613	$df = 3$, $p = 0.306$

Source: own processing

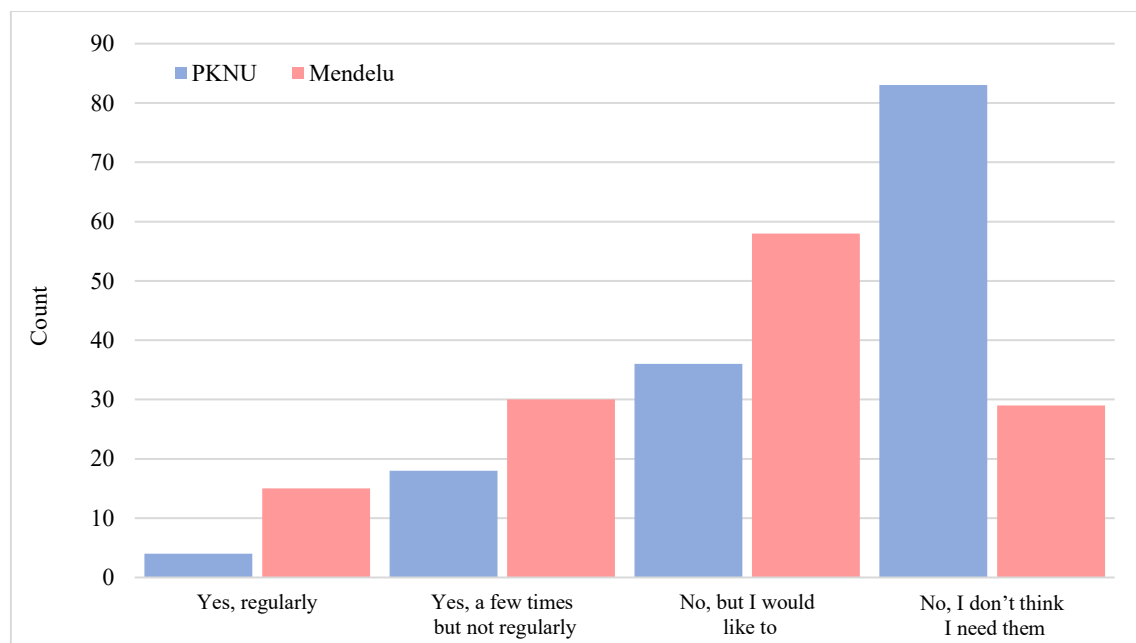
Following the analysis of perceived lifestyle support for mental well-being, the next step was to examine cross-national differences in the use of mental health services. Students were asked “*Have you ever used mental-health services during your studies (e.g., counselling)?*” Their responses were grouped into four categories ranging from “No, I don’t think I need it” to “Yes, regularly,” and the distribution of these categories was compared between Czech and Korean students.

Figure 7 illustrates that there is a clear difference between the two groups. Among Czech students, the most common response was “No, but I would like to,” indicating a relatively high level of interest in accessing mental-health support despite not having used it yet. In contrast, Korean students most frequently selected “No, I don’t think I need it,” suggesting a lower perceived need for such services. Regular use of mental-health

services was uncommon in both groups, although slightly more frequent among Czech students.

Figure 7 Mental health service use among Czech and Korean students

(PKNU_n = 141, Mendel_n = 132)



Source: own processing

These patterns were confirmed by a chi-square test assessing whether the distribution of mental-health service use differed between the two countries. As shown in Table 20, the association between country and mental-health service use was statistically significant ($\chi^2 = 40.300$, $df = 3$, $p < 0.001$), indicating substantial cross-national differences in how students engage with or perceive the need for mental-health support services.

Table 20 Mental health service use among students (Chi-Square Test)

Mental health service use	CZ (n = 132)	KR (n = 141)
No, I don't think I need it	29 (22.0%)	83 (58.9%)
No, but I would like to	58 (43.9%)	36 (25.5%)
Yes, a few times	30 (22.7%)	18 (12.8%)
Yes, regularly	15 (11.4%)	4 (2.8%)
Chi-Square (χ^2)	40.300	df = 3, p < 0.001

Source: own processing

Evaluation: The results partially support the hypotheses. H06a was retained, as no significant difference was found in perceived lifestyle support for mental well-being between students ($\chi^2 = 3.613, p = .306$). In contrast, H06b was rejected, since the use of mental-health services differed significantly across countries ($\chi^2 = 40.300, p < 0.001$) with Czech students expressing greater interest in accessing counselling.

4.5 Cultural and Social Perceptions

RQ₇ examined how Czech and Korean university students perceive cultural and social expectations related to academic success, work intensity, wellbeing, and family influence. These items reflect broader societal attitudes toward achievement and personal balance.

Table 21 Descriptive statistics for cultural perceptions among Czech and Korean students

Variable	Country	Mean	Median	SD
Academic success over well-being	KR	3.99	4	0.898
	CZ	3.72	4	1.114
Success judged by grades/status	KR	4.16	4	0.864
	CZ	3.55	4	1.148
Long study/work hours limit free time	KR	4.10	4	0.856
	CZ	3.98	4	1.059
Undervaluation of well-being	KR	4.21	4	0.806
	CZ	3.89	4	1.065
Family/social expectations influence decisions	KR	3.95	4	1.009
	CZ	2.83	3	0.990

Source: own processing

Table 21 presents the descriptive statistics for five cultural-perception items. Across most statements, Korean students reported higher agreement, indicating stronger perceived societal pressure toward academic achievement, performance-based evaluation, and family influence. Czech students showed lower mean values on four of the five items, suggesting a comparatively less pressure-driven perception of academic and social expectations.

The largest cross-national difference appeared for family/social expectations influencing academic or career decisions, where Korean students scored substantially higher

($M = 3.95$) than Czech students ($M = 2.83$). Korean students also more strongly endorsed the view that success is judged mainly by grades or career status ($M = 4.16$ vs. 3.55 CZ) and that well-being and rest are undervalued ($M = 4.21$ vs. 3.89 CZ). Differences were smaller for the perception that academic success is prioritized over well-being ($M = 3.99$ KR vs. 3.72 CZ) and for long study/work hours limiting free time, where both groups reported similarly high agreement.

Independent-samples t-tests (Table 22) confirmed significant cross-national differences for four of the five cultural-perception items that were evident in the descriptive statistics. The results indicate that Korean students perceive stronger societal pressure related to academic performance, cultural expectations, and family influence. The only non-significant difference was found for the perception that long study/work hours are socially expected ($p = 0.295$). The effect sizes ranged from small to very large (Cohen's $d = 0.13$ – 1.12), indicating that while some cultural differences were modest, family and social expectations showed a particularly strong practical impact.

Table 22 Group differences in cultural perceptions between Czech and Korean students

Variable	t	MD	p	Cohen d
Academic success over well-being	2.237	0.273	0.026	0.271
Success judged by grades/status	4.984	0.611	< 0.001	0.604
Long study/work hours as success indicator	1.050	0.122	0.295	0.127
Undervaluation of well-being	2.738	0.312	0.007	0.332
Family/social expectations influence decisions	9.223	1.117	< 0.001	1.117

Source: own processing

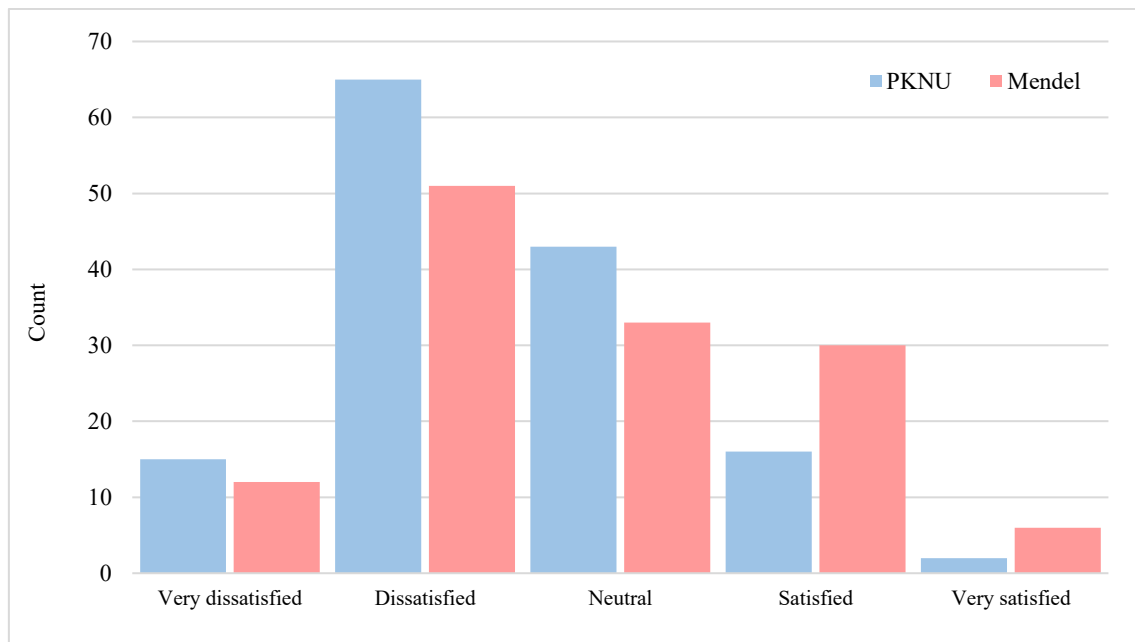
Evaluation: The analysis led to partial rejection of the hypotheses. $H0_{7a}$, $H0_{7b}$, $H0_{7d}$, and $H0_{7e}$ were rejected, as significant cross-national differences were found in perceptions of academic success, performance-based evaluation, undervaluation of well-being, and family influence. Meanwhile $H0_{7c}$ was retained, since no significant difference emerged regarding the expectation of long study or work hours.

4.6 Life Satisfaction

RQ₈ explored how Czech and Korean university students evaluate their overall life satisfaction. The analysis focused on the single item assessing overall satisfaction with work–study–life balance, which reflects students’ subjective evaluation of how well they manage competing demands of university life and personal well-being.

Figure 8 Life satisfaction with WSLB among Czech and Korean students

(PKNU_n = 141, Mendel_n = 132)



Source: own processing

The distribution of responses in Figure 8 shows clear cross-national differences in students’ overall satisfaction with their WSLB. Korean students reported substantially lower satisfaction, with approximately 63% falling into the “Very dissatisfied” or “Dissatisfied” categories, compared to about 52% among Czech students. Neutral responses were also slightly more common in the Korean sample (around 28%) than in the Czech sample (about 23%). In contrast, Czech students expressed higher levels of positive satisfaction, with roughly 22% selecting “Satisfied” or “Very satisfied,” whereas only around 12% of Korean students reported similarly positive evaluations. These differences are also reflected in the mean scores, where Czech students reported a higher average satisfaction level ($M = 2.75$) compared to Korean students ($M = 2.47$).

An independent samples t-test was conducted (presented in Table 23) to compare overall satisfaction with WSLB between Czech and Korean students. The results revealed a statistically significant difference between the two groups, with Czech students reporting higher satisfaction ($M = 2.75$, $SD = 1.05$) than Korean students ($M = 2.47$, $SD = 0.88$). The mean difference was 0.28 points. This difference was statistically significant, $t(256.48) = 2.39$, $p = .018$, with a small effect size (Cohen's $d = 0.295$).

Table 23 Group differences in life satisfaction with WSLB between students

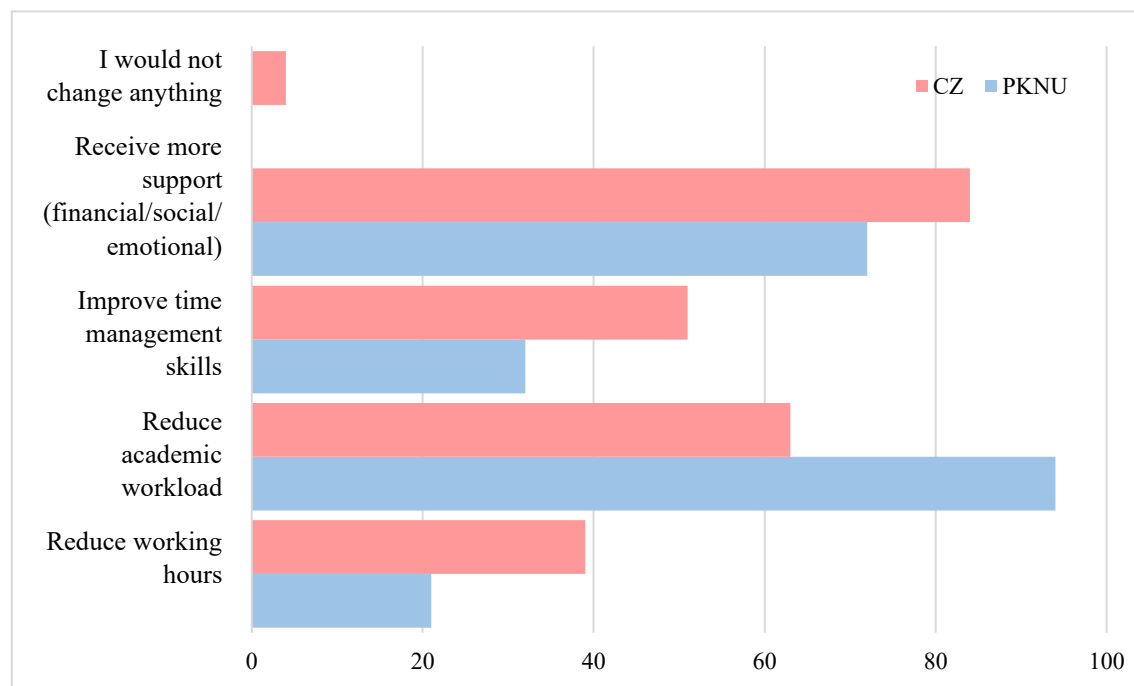
Variable	t	MD	p	Cohen d
Life satisfaction	2.394	0.281	0.018	0.295

Source: own processing

After reporting their overall life satisfaction, students were also asked whether they would change anything to improve their work–study–life balance. Their responses, summarized in Figure 9.

Figure 9 Preferred changes to improve WSLB among Czech and Korean students

(PKNU = 219, Mendel = 241)



Source: own processing

Czech students most frequently selected receiving more support (34.9%), followed by reducing academic workload (26.1%). Korean students most often indicated reducing

academic workload (42.9%), while receiving more support was the second most frequent response (32.9%). Czech students were also more likely to report improving time management skills (21.2%) and reducing working hours (16.2%) than Korean students. Only a very small proportion of respondents stated that they would not change anything.

A chi-square test of independence was conducted to examine differences between Czech and Korean students regarding changes they would make to improve their WSLB. The results revealed a statistically significant association between country and preferred changes, $\chi^2 (4) = 19.79$, $p < 0.001$.

Table 24 Preferred changes to improve WSLB among students (Chi-Square Test)

Preferred changes to improve WSLB	CZ (n = 241)	KR (n = 219)
Reduce working hours	39 (16.2%)	21 (9.6%)
Reduce academic workload	63 (26.1%)	94 (42.9%)
Improve time management skills	51 (21.2%)	32 (14.6%)
Receive more support (financial/social/emotional)	84 (34.9%)	72 (32.9%)
I would not change anything	4 (1.7%)	0 (0.0%)
Chi-Square (χ^2)	19.79	df = 4, $p < 0.001$

Source: own processing

Evaluation: The results led to the rejection of H_{08a} , as Czech and Korean students differed significantly in their overall satisfaction with work–study–life balance. Czech students reported higher mean satisfaction levels than their Korean counterparts, and this difference was confirmed by a statistically significant t-test with a small effect size. In addition, the chi-square analysis of preferred changes to improve balance revealed further cross-national variation in the types of adjustments students would make.

5 Discussion

The analysis of time allocation discovered marked differences between the two student groups, particularly in study hours and engagement in paid work. Korean students reported substantially higher study time than Czech students. This is supported by Park and Kim (2018), who describe the Korean educational environment as shaped by long instructional hours, extensive after-school tutoring, and strong academic expectations. This interpretation is further recognized by Kim, Shin and Park (2023), who argue that these conditions contribute to a culture in which sustained study effort is normalized and socially expected. However, as implied by the results, Czech students devoted significantly more time to paid work and household duties. This is consistent with European trends identified by Cuppen et al. (2024), who note that student employment is widespread and frequently financially necessary. Majerová and Sokolová (2025) further explain that the higher domestic workload among students may also reflect cultural expectations regarding independence and self-management during university years, which supports the Czech results. Despite these objective differences, both groups reported similar perceptions of time availability and ability to rest and as explained by Vokić et al. (2021), work–study–life balance is shaped not only by workload but also by subjective norms, coping strategies, and broader cultural expectations.

Several studies (Amez et al., 2021; Bjarntof et al., 2020; Siem et al., 2025) have revealed that students often struggle to maintain balance regarding their personal time, physical health or relationships. In accordance with the results, both Czech and Korean students experienced considerable pressure on their personal time resulting from academic and work demands. However, clearer differences appeared in health and relationship strain as Czech students reported significantly higher levels of tension. This may reflect Hauschildt (2019), who argue that well-being is closely tied to maintaining personal health and stable social relationships, and disruptions in these areas are often perceived as clear signs of imbalance. According to Yon et al. (2023), East Asian academic cultures often normalize physical strain as part of academic commitment while placing strong emphasis on resilience and educational achievement. This may explain the reduction of perceived seriousness of health- and relationship-related interference among Korean students.

Regarding wellbeing, Korean students reported significantly higher academic stress, social expectation stress, and stress related to future uncertainty. As Zaitouni et al. (2024) discussed, students in highly competitive environments often internalize academic demands as a central part of their identity, which intensifies stress responses. The strong association between academic and social expectation stress and anxiety among Korean students in this study further supports this interpretation. These findings agree with Dave (2018), who argues that when social norms emphasize duty, performance, and conformity, psychological strain becomes a common consequence of role overload. However, Czech students experienced significantly higher work-related stress, reflecting the fact that Czech students commonly engage in part-time employment alongside their studies. Borowiec & Drygas (2023) assert that in European contexts, especially in post-transition economies, employment demands are a major source of strain and are strongly linked to poorer mental and physical health. Marecki (2024) similarly emphasizes that insufficient time and high workload are key mechanisms through which work-life imbalance deteriorates well-being. Furthermore, both groups reported comparable levels of stress related to lack of personal time, and in both samples this variable was the strongest predictor of emotional exhaustion. This finding is consistent with El-Qebaisi (2025), who claims that time inadequacy is one of the most universal determinants of well-being across cultures.

The emotional well-being variables also show clear cultural differences. Czech students reported higher emotional exhaustion and perceived inability to cope, which may reflect the cumulative burden of employment and study. Hendriks (2020) found that students who juggle multiple roles experience more fatigue and reduce coping capacity. Korean students, on the other hand, reported higher anxiety and overload.

A striking difference emerged in the use of mental health services. Czech students expressed greater willingness to seek counselling, whereas Korean students most frequently reported that they did not believe they needed professional support. This pattern is supported by study done by Kim et al. (2023) who documented cultural stigma around mental health in East Asian societies. Additionally, McCloughen et al. (2016) highlight that in many collectivist cultures, psychological difficulties are perceived as a personal failure, which may discourage help-seeking behavior. The fact that perceptions of lifestyle support did not differ significantly between groups suggests

that the barrier is not lifestyle quality itself, but cultural attitudes toward mental health (Kokosadze & Lortkipanidze, 2023).

Furthermore, the findings indicate that Korean students perceive stronger cultural and social pressure related to academic success, performance expectations, and family influence than Czech students. This pattern is consistent with studies showing that East Asian societies are strongly collectivistic, where parental expectations and obligations heavily shape educational and career choices, as argued by Park and Kim (2018). Similarly, Byun and Kim (2010) describe Confucian-heritage education systems, which emphasize discipline, competition, and status-based achievement, which align with the stronger emphasis on grades and career prestige in Korea. In contrast, the lower level of perceived pressure among Czech students reflects European cultural norms that prioritize autonomy, personal well-being, and self-directed decision making, as noted by Borowiec and Drygas (2023) in their analysis of European work–life balance orientations.

Finally, the results of life satisfaction revealed that Czech students reported significantly higher satisfaction with their work–study–life balance compared to Korean students. This finding is consistent with Kim et al. (2023), who also report lower life satisfaction among Korean students. In addition, Korean students most frequently expressed a desire to reduce their academic workload, whereas Czech students more often emphasized improving time management and reducing working hours. This difference reflects the structural contexts described earlier, where Korean students primarily seek relief from academic intensity, while Czech students aim to better balance academic and work demands. Hollmann (2024) similarly highlights that institutional flexibility, and support structures play a crucial role in shaping students' perceived work–life balance.

5.1 Limitations of the Study

This thesis has several limitations that should be considered when interpreting the findings. First, the research sample consisted solely of students from two universities, Pukyong National University in South Korea and Mendel University in the Czech Republic. While both institutions provided valuable insight into the experiences of their students, the results cannot be generalized to all Czech or Korean university students. Differences in institutional culture, academic environments, and student characteristics across other universities may lead to different outcomes

The research did not account for certain demographic or academic differences that may shape students' work–study–life balance. In particular, the analysis did not examine potential variations between male and female students or between students enrolled in different types of study programs, which may differ in workload and expectations. Considering these distinctions could offer a more nuanced understanding of how different groups of students experience well-being.

Another limitation concerns the linguistic and cultural aspects of the data collection process. Although the questionnaire was translated from English into Korean with attention to clarity and accuracy, subtle differences in language and cultural interpretation may still have influenced how some items were understood. Cultural norms related to expressing stress, well-being, or personal challenges may also have shaped the way students interpreted and responded to certain questions.

A further limitation concerns the nature of the data collection itself. The study was based on an online questionnaire that included several personal and sensitive questions related to stress, well-being, and students' everyday routines. While most participants appeared willing to share their experiences, some may have felt reluctant to respond fully due to their personal character.

6 Conclusion

The purpose of this diploma thesis was to examine how university students in South Korea and the Czech Republic perceive and experience the balance between academic demands, work responsibilities, and personal life, and how this balance relates to their overall well-being. To achieve this aim, the thesis was structured into three main parts, including a theoretical overview, a methodological framework, and a quantitative analysis based on data collected from Mendel University and Pukyong National University students.

The theoretical section provided the conceptual foundation for understanding work–study–life balance, well-being, stress, and cultural influences on student behavior. The methodological part outlined the research design, sampling strategy, and the eight research questions guiding the empirical investigation.

The empirical analysis offered a detailed comparison of Czech and Korean students across multiple domains. The first research question, which examined how students allocate their time between study, work, personal life, sleep, and household duties, revealed clear structural differences. Korean students devoted more time to studying, whereas Czech students spent significantly more time working and managing domestic responsibilities. The second research question, focused on perceived time availability and rest ability, showed that despite these objective differences, subjective time management perceptions were relatively similar across both groups.

The third research question explored how study–work demands affect personal time, health, and relationships. While both groups reported comparable pressure on personal time, Czech students experienced stronger effects in the areas of health and relationships. The fourth and fifth research questions, addressing stress and emotional well-being, demonstrated that Korean students faced higher academic, social, and future-related stress, whereas Czech students reported greater work-related strain, emotional exhaustion, and difficulties coping.

The sixth research question revealed no significant differences in perceived lifestyle support for mental well-being, yet substantial disparities emerged in mental-health service use, with Czech students showing a higher willingness to seek support.

The seventh research question highlighted pronounced cultural contrasts, with Korean students perceiving stronger societal and family pressure related to academic success, performance-based evaluation, and undervaluation of well-being. Finally, the last research question showed that overall life satisfaction with work–study–life balance was moderate in both groups, though shaped by different stressors and cultural expectations.

In conclusion, the findings of this thesis provide broader insight into how students in two culturally distinct environments navigate the competing demands of study, work, and personal life. Although the Czech and Korean groups differed in their time-use patterns, stress profiles, and cultural expectations, both faced significant challenges that shaped their well-being during university studies. These results highlight that student well-being is not determined by a single factor but emerges from the interaction of academic structures, employment conditions, cultural norms, and individual coping capacities.

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List of Figures

Figure 1 Overview of research questions and hypotheses for time allocation	38
Figure 2 Overview of research question and hypotheses for work-study-life balance .	38
Figure 3 Overview of research questions and hypotheses for wellbeing and stress.....	40
Figure 4 Overview of the research question and hypotheses for cultural perceptions ..	41
Figure 5 Overview of the research question and hypothesis for life satisfaction.....	41
Figure 6 Perceived lifestyle support for wellbeing among Czech and Korean students	57
Figure 7 Mental health service use among Czech and Korean students	59
Figure 8 Life satisfaction with WSLB among Czech and Korean students	62
Figure 9 Preferred changes to improve WSLB among Czech and Korean students	63

List of Tables

Table 1 Demographic characteristics of Korean participants	42
Table 2 Demographic characteristics of Czech participants.....	43
Table 3 Employment status of Mendel and PKNU students (full sample).....	44
Table 4 Employment types among employed students (analytical sample).....	45
Table 5 Descriptive statistics of time allocation among Czech and Korean students ...	46
Table 6 Group differences in time allocation between Czech and Korean students	46
Table 7 Descriptive statistics of time management among Czech and Korean students	47
Table 8 Group differences in time management between Czech and Korean students .	48
Table 9 Spearman correlations between time-allocation and subjective time-management among Czech and Korean students.....	48
Table 10 Descriptive statistics for WSLB conflict among Czech and Korean students	50
Table 11 Group differences in WSLB conflict between Czech and Korean students ...	50
Table 12 Spearman correlations between time allocation and WSLB conflict among Czech and Korean students	51

Table 13 Descriptive statistics of stress levels among Czech and Korean students	52
Table 14 Group differences in stress levels between Czech and Korean students	52
Table 15 Descriptive statistics of emotional wellbeing among Czech and Korean students	53
Table 16 Group differences in emotional well-being between Czech and Korean students	54
Table 17 Spearman correlations between stress domains and emotional well-being among Czech and Korean students.....	55
Table 18 Regression for emotional exhaustion among Czech and Korean students	56
Table 19 Perceived lifestyle support among students (Chi-Square Test)	58
Table 20 Mental health service use among students (Chi-Square Test).....	59
Table 21 Descriptive statistics for cultural perceptions among Czech and Korean students	60
Table 22 Group differences in cultural perceptions between Czech and Korean students	61
Table 23 Group differences in life satisfaction with WSLB between students	63
Table 24 Preferred changes to improve WSLB among students (Chi-Square Test)	64

List of Abbreviations

BT – Boundary Theory

CZ – Czech Republic

FRDIS – Faculty of Regional Development and International Studies

HRV – Heart Rate Variability

I–C – Individualism vs. Collectivism

KR – South Korea

ILO – International Labour Organization

IVR – Indulgence vs. Restraint

LTO – Long-Term Orientation

MAS – Masculinity vs. Femininity

MENDEL – Mendel University in Brno

NREM – Non-Rapid Eye Movement Sleep

OECD – Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development

PDI – Power Distance Index

PKNU – Pukyong National University

RCT – Role Conflict Theory

REM – Rapid Eye Movement Sleep

RO – Role Overload

RST – Role Strain Theory

WLB – Work–Life Balance

WSLB – Work–Study–Life Balance

Attachments

Attachment 1: Questionnaire (Korean version)

학생들의 워라벨(일과 삶의 균형)에 관한 설문조사 - 부경대학교 학생 대상

연구자: 체코 공화국 멘델 대학교 학생, Natálie Svobodová입니다.

목적: 본 연구는 부경대학교 학생들이 학업, 아르바이트, 개인 생활을 어떻게 균형 있게 관리하는지 조사하고자 합니다. 현재 학업과 아르바이트를 하는 학생들을 대상으로 조사한 결과는 웰빙, 학업 성취도, 삶의 만족도에 미치는 영향을 이해하는 데 도움이 될 것입니다.

기밀성: 모든 응답은 익명으로 처리되며, 학술 연구 목적으로만 사용됩니다.A)
인구통계학적 정보

A) 인구통계학적 정보

성별은 무엇인가요?

- 남성
- 여성
- 기타

나이는 어떻게 되시나요?

.....

어느 단과대학에 재학 중이신가요?

- 인문사회과학대학
- 경영대학
- 공과대학
- 수산과학대학

- 환경·해양과학기술대학
- 자연과학대학

어떤 학위 과정을 하는 중인가요?

- 학사
- 석사
- 박사

현재 일하거나 인턴십을 하고 있습니까?

- 예, 파트타임 근무
- 예, 풀타임 근무
- 예, 무급 파트타임 인턴십
- 예, 무급 풀타임 인턴십
- 아니요, 현재 일하거나 인턴십을 하지 않음

B) 시간표를 관리

평일에는 일반적으로 다음 활동에 각각 몇 시간을 보내신가요?

(숫자로 써 주십시오)

- 학업(강의, 과제, 자습): ____ 시간
- 일(인턴십 포함): _____ 시간
- 개인 시간(사회 활동, 취미 등): _____ 시간
- 수면: _____ 시간
- 가사/집안일: _____ 시간

다음 문항에 대해 얼마나 동의하는지 평가해 주세요.

(1 = 전혀 동의하지 않음; 5 = 매우 동의함)

- 학업 및 업무 관련 의무를 수행할 시간이 충분하다.
- 학업, 일, 개인 활동 사이에서 하루 일정을 효율적으로 조절할 수 있다.
- 나의 일상은 규칙적인 휴식과 회복을 가능하게 한다.
- 대부분의 날에 나는 일정이 잘 정리되어 있다고 느낀다.

C) 학업-일-개인 생활의 균형

학업과 일의 균형에 대한 인식

(1 = 전혀 동의하지 않음; 5 = 매우 동의함)

- 학업과 업무량은 나의 개인 생활 시간을 영향을 준다.
- 업무나 학업 때문에 신체적·정신적 건강 관리를 소홀히 할 때가 있다.
- 학업과 일을 병행하는 것은 가까운 사람들과의 관계에 영향을 준다.
- 바쁜 일정 속에서도 나에게 즐거움을 주는 활동을 위한 시간을 찾을 수 있다.

학업과 일의 균형에 대한 인식

(1 = 전혀 동의하지 않음; 5 = 매우 동의함)

- 나는 나의 의무를 효과적으로 수행한다고 생각한다.
- 학업, 일, 개인 활동을 조직하는 데 있어 스스로 유능하다고 느낀다.
- 중요한 활동을 할 수 있을 만큼 충분한 에너지가 있다.
- 현재 삶의 여러 영역 사이의 균형을 잘 유지하고 있다고 느낀다.

D) 스트레스와 정서적 웰빙

현재 다음 요소들이 얼마나 스트레스로 느껴지나요?

(스트레스 척도: 1 = 전혀 스트레스 없음; 5 = 극심한 스트레스)

- 학업량
- 직장 의무
- 개인 시간 부족
- 경제적 압박
- 사회적 기대(가족, 동료)
- 미래에 대한 불확실성

학업 및/또는 직장 책임으로 인해 현재 다음 감정을 얼마나 자주 느끼신가요?

(1 = 전혀 동의하지 않음; 5 = 매우 동의함)

- 정서적으로 지친다.

- 불안감을 느낀다.
- 대처할 수 없다고 느낀다.
- 행복하고 편안하다.
- 집중되고 동기 부여를 느낀다.

현재의 생활 방식이 정신적 웰빙을 도움을 줍니까요?

- 아니요
- 그렇지 않은 편이다
- 그런 편이다
- 예
- 기타

학업 중에 정신 건강 서비스(예: 상담)를 이용해본 적이 있나요?

- 예, 정기적으로
- 예, 한두 번
- 아니요, 하지만 이용하고 싶다
- 아니요, 필요하지 않다

E) 문화적 및 사회적 인식

각 문항에 대해 얼마나 동의하는지 평가해 주세요.

(1 = 전혀 동의하지 않음; 5 = 매우 동의함)

- 학업과 직업적 성공은 매우 중요하게 여겨진다.
- 성공은 종종 학업 성취나 직업적 지위로 정의된다.
- 장시간 일하거나 공부하는 것은 성공의 정상적이고 기대되는 부분으로 여겨진다.
- 휴식과 개인적 웰빙을 위한 시간은 사회적으로 용인되고 권장된다.
- 취미나 휴식과 같은 여가 활동은 삶의 의미 있는 부분으로 여겨진다.
- 나의 학업 또는 직업적 결정은 가족이나 사회적 관계의 영향을 받는다.

귀하의 문화적 또는 사회적 환경에서 다음 가치가 얼마나 강조되는지 평가해 주세요.

(1 = 전혀 강조되지 않음; 5 = 매우 강조됨)

- 학업 성취
- 직업적 또는 경제적 성공
- 사회적 또는 가족적 책임
- 정신적 및 정서적 건강
- 취미와 휴식을 위한 여유시간

F) 전반적인 만족도

현재의 학업-일-생활 균형에 대해 전반적으로 얼마나 만족하시나요?

- 매우 만족
- 만족
- 중립
- 불만족
- 매우 불만족

워라벨을 개선하기 위해 바꾸고 싶은 것이 있다면 무엇인가요?

(모두 선택 가능)

- 근무 시간 줄이기
- 학업량 줄이기
- 시간 관리 기술 향상
- 더 많은 지원 받기(경제적/사회적/정서적)
- 기타(구체적으로): _____
- 바꾸고 싶은 것 없음 아무것도 바꾸고 싶지 않음

Pracovní a studijní rovnováha vysokoškolských studentů v České republice a Jižní Koreji

Autor: Bc. Natálie Svobodová, Mendelova univerzita v Brně

Prosím, věnuj několik minut svého času vyplnění tohoto dotazníku pro moji diplomovou práci.

Účel: Tato studie se zaměřuje na to, jak studenti na Mendelově univerzitě v Česku a Pukyong National University v Jižní Koreji zvládají rovnováhu mezi studijními povinnostmi, pracím a osobním životem. Hlavní pozornost je věnována studentům, kteří jsou během studia zaměstnaní. Vaše odpovědi mi pomohou lépe porozumět tomu, jak tato rovnováha ovlivňuje duševní pohodu, studijní úspěšnost a celkovou spokojenost se životem.

Důvěrnost: Všechny odpovědi jsou anonymní a budou použity pro akademické účely.

A) DEMOGRAFICKÉ ÚDAJE

POHLAVÍ

- ☐ Muž
- ☐ Žena
- ☐ Další

VĚK

.....otevřená otázka

FAKULTA

- ☐ Agronomická fakulta
- ☐ Provozně ekonomická fakulta
- ☐ Lesnická a dřevařská fakulta
- ☐ Zahradnická fakulta
- ☐ Fakulta regionálního rozvoje a mezinárodních studií
- ☐ Institut celoživotního vzdělávání

STUDIUM

- ☐ Bakalářské studium
- ☐ Magisterské studium
- ☐ Doktorské studium

Vykonáváš v současnosti nějakou formu práce nebo stáže?

- Ano, pracuji na částečný úvazek
- Ano, pracuji na plný úvazek
- Ano, vykonávám neplacenou stáž na částečný úvazek
- Ano, vykonávám neplacenou stáž na plný úvazek
- Ne, momentálně nejsem zaměstnaný/á, nevykonávám stáž

B) ČASOVÁ ZÁTĚŽ

Níže uveď, kolik hodin obvykle trávíš během pracovního dne jednotlivými aktivitami.

(otevřené číselné odpovědi)

- Studium (přednášky, úkoly, samostudium): ____ hodin
- Práce/stáž: ____ hodin
- Osobní čas (setkávání s přáteli, koníčky apod.): ____ hodin
- Spánek: ____ hodin
- Domácí nebo pečovatelské povinnosti: ____ hodin

Ohodnot' míru svého souhlasu s následujícími tvrzeními na škále od 1 do 5.

(1 = Rozhodně nesouhlasím | 5 = Rozhodně souhlasím)

- Mám dostatek času na splnění svých studijních a pracovních povinností.
- Umím si efektivně rozvrhnout den mezi studium, práci a osobní aktivity.
- Můj denní režim mi umožňuje pravidelný odpočinek a regeneraci.
- Většinu dní se cítím dobře zorganizovaný/á.

C) ROVNOVÁHA MEZI PRACÍ, STUDIEM A OSOBNÍM ŽIVOTEM

Ohodnot' míru svého souhlasu s následujícími tvrzeními na škále od 1 do 5.

(1 = Rozhodně nesouhlasím | 5 = Rozhodně souhlasím)

- Množství studijních a pracovních povinností ovlivňuje můj čas na osobní život.
- Kvůli povinnostem někdy zanedbávám péči o své fyzické zdraví.
- Kombinace studia a práce má dopad na kvalitu mých vztahů s blízkými.
- I při náročném rozvrhu si dokážu najít čas na aktivity, které mi přinášejí radost.

Ohodnot' míru svého souhlasu s následujícími tvrzeními na škále od 1 do 5.

(1 = Rozhodně nesouhlasím | 5 = Rozhodně souhlasím)

- Myslím, že své povinnosti zvládám efektivně.
- Cítím se kompetentní v tom, jak si organizuji studijní, pracovní a osobní aktivity.
- Mám dostatek energie na činnosti, které považuji za důležité.

D) DUŠEVNÍ POHODA

Níže ohodnoť, jak stresující jsou pro tebe aktuálně následující oblasti.

(Stupnice stresu: 1 = Velmi nestresující | 5 = Stresující)

- Studijní zátěž
- Pracovní povinnost
- Nedostatek osobního času
- Finanční tlak
- Společenská očekávání (rodina, vrstevníci)
- Nejistota ohledně budoucnosti

Níže najdeš výroky týkající se tvých pocitů. Vyber, do jaké míry s nimi souhlasíš.

(1 = Rozhodně nesouhlasím | 5 = Rozhodně souhlasím)

- Cítím se emocionálně vyčerpaný/á
- Cítím se úzkostně nebo přetížene
- Mám pocit, že své povinnosti nezvládám

Máš pocit, že tvůj současný životní styl podporuje tvoji duševní pohodu?

- Ne
- Spíše ne
- Spíše ano
- Ano
- Ostatní

Využil/a jsi někdy během studia služeb duševního zdraví (např. poradenství)?

- Ano, pravidelně
- Ano, párkrát ale ne pravidelně
- Ne, ale rád/a bych
- Ne, nemyslím si, že to potřebuji

E) KULTURNÍ A SPOLEČENKÉ VNÍMÁNÍ

Níže uvedená tvrzení se týkají kulturního a společenského prostředí, ve kterém žiješ.

Ohodnot' míru svého souhlasu na škále od 1 do 5.

(1 = Rozhodně nesouhlasím | 5 = Rozhodně souhlasím)

- Akademický a kariérní úspěch je často kladen nad osobní pohodou.
- Úspěch bývá většinou hodnocen podle známek nebo profesního statusu, spíše než podle osobního uspokojení.
- Dlouhé hodiny práce nebo studia jsou běžně očekávány a někdy brání volnému času.
- Well-being (osobní pohoda) a odpočinek není vždy plně podporována nebo oceňována.
- Rodina a společenské okolí mají často vliv na moje akademická nebo kariérní rozhodnutí.

Ohodnot', jak silně jsou následující hodnoty zdůrazňovány ve tvém kulturním nebo společenském prostředí na škále od 1 do 5.

(1 - vůbec, 5 - velmi)

- Akademické úspěchy
- Kariérní nebo finanční úspěch
- Společenské nebo rodinné povinnosti
- Duševní a emocionální zdraví
- Čas na koníčky a relaxaci

F) CELKOVÁ SPOKOJENOST A REFLEXE

Níže ohodnot' svou celkovou spokojenost s rovnováhou mezi prací, studiem a osobním životem.

- Velmi spokojený/á
- Spokojený/á
- Neutrální
- Nespokojený/á
- Velmi nespokojený/á

Pokud bys mohl/a něco změnit, aby se tvoje rovnováha zlepšila, co by to bylo?

((Vyberte všechny možnosti, které platí))

- Snížit počet pracovních hodin
- Snížit studijní zátěž

- Zlepšit dovednosti v oblasti time management
- Získat více podpory (finanční/společenské/emocionální)
- Nic bych neměnil/a
- Další: